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Seventy-ninth session

Official Records

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New York

President: Mr. Yang (Cameroon)

In the absence of the President, Mrs. Kasymalieva (Kyrgyzstan), Vice-President, took the Chair.

The meeting was called to order at 3.20 p.m.

Address by Mr. Mohamed Ould Cheikh El Ghazouani, President of the Islamic Republic of Mauritania

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Islamic Republic of Mauritania.

Mr. Mohamed Ould Cheikh El Ghazouani, President of the Islamic Republic of Mauritania, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Mohamed Ould Cheikh El Ghazouani, President of the Islamic Republic of Mauritania, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President El Ghazouani (*spoke in Arabic*): I would like to begin by extending my warmest congratulations to His Excellency Mr. Philemon Yang on his presidency of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session and by wishing him every success at its helm.

I would also like to commend His Excellency Mr. Dennis Francis for the immense wisdom and effectiveness with which he steered the work of the seventy-eighth session of the General Assembly.

Allow me also to express my great appreciation for the efforts of His Excellency Secretary-General António Guterres to strengthen our Organization and enhance its role as an effective institutional expression of our collective will to address the various challenges that confront our world on the path to comprehensive sustainable development.

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The theme of our summit — leaving no one behind and acting together for the advancement of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations — powerfully and clearly encapsulates the goals and objectives of the Charter of the United Nations while reflecting the depth of our collective awareness of the need to enhance our cooperation and coordinate our efforts in order to address the existing challenges. What the world has undergone and is currently experiencing, in terms of violent shocks and unprecedented crises at various levels, has considerably undermined our individual and collective ability to honour the commitments we made in the context of the Agenda for Sustainable Development.

The current international situation is having a very negative impact on efforts to achieve sustainable development, especially on our African continent, which is already affected by structural and circumstantial imbalances and obstacles that are hindering its development efforts and retarding its progress towards fulfilling the two harmonious Agendas: the United Nations Agenda for Sustainable Development and the African Union's Agenda 2063. Our continent continues to be blighted by poverty, vulnerability, unemployment, healthcare and educational systems that are of poor quality and lack universality, not to mention the spread of terrorism and armed conflict and the devastating effects of climate change. The bleak outlook in Africa greatly underscores the urgent need to relieve African countries of their enormous debt burden and to rectify the obvious imbalances in the development assistance system and in international governance, in terms of both political and financial governance, and to strengthen multilateral cooperation in general. Addressing all of those issues could propel the continent towards economic growth in a way that contributes to efforts to fulfil the commitments made by the international community in relation to the 2030 Agenda.

In line with those commitments, we, in the Islamic Republic of Mauritania, have made achieving the Sustainable Development Goals the focus of all of our public policies. We have been able to make strides, be they slight, on many of the Sustainable Development Goal indicators, and that progress is reflected in our somewhat-improved ranking among the countries listed in the United Nations Global Sustainable Development Report 2024. That progress is the result of intensive efforts aimed at consolidating the rule of law and strong institutions, promoting democracy and individual and collective freedoms, using dialogue and consultation as a permanent tool in the management of public affairs, bolstering the independence of the judiciary, fostering transparency and combating all forms of corruption and bribery affecting administrative and financial matters. Our ongoing efforts to protect and promote human rights have also entailed combating modern and old forms of slavery and human trafficking, protecting the rights of women and children and combating irregular migration and cross-border crime.

On top of all that, we have been able to achieve security, peace and stability despite the current situation in our region and worldwide. Violence and terrorism continue to prevail, as do political and social crises, but with the help of Allah and our national integrated security strategy, we were able to make those gains. Likewise, we have afforded considerable attention to the role of young people in the country's development and growth. Our focus is on developing plans and strategies to guarantee that young people receive an education, develop skills, are integrated into society and have a greater presence in various spheres of public life.

All of the above has contributed to greater national unity and social cohesion. To achieve that, we stepped up efforts to eliminate various forms of exclusion, injustice and vulnerability by creating an extensive and multifaceted social safety net that seeks to alleviate the burdens on the poorest arising from the limitations and precariousness of daily life so as to increase their resilience to those difficulties and to enhance their access to all public services. We have also launched promising

educational reforms with the aim of establishing a republican schooling system that embodies the values of equality and fairness and guarantees everyone equal access to a high-quality education that will be a springboard for social advancement. In tandem, we have redoubled efforts to expand and improve the scope of the health services offered to our population and to ensure access to medication. We have introduced a health insurance system for citizens who are not covered by standard insurance programmes. In addition, we are providing some basic medical services free of charge, especially for mothers, older persons and persons with disabilities.

We are alive to the adverse effects of climate change and other environmental challenges on our planet, the economy and society, and we are aware of the political and security implications, in particular for the African continent and the Sahel, specifically. We have endeavoured to reduce our carbon emissions by 11 per cent and to raise the proportion of renewable energy sources in our total energy mix to 50 per cent by 2030. We intend to step up our efforts in that area and to introduce an extensive green hydrogen development programme. In addition to our efforts to promote clean energy technology, which now accounts for 48 per cent of our energy use, we are continuing to fight against desertification in the context of the Great Green Wall initiative and the Permanent Interstate Committee for Drought Control in the Sahel.

Against that backdrop, I welcome the outcome of the twenty-eighth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, which was hosted by the United Arab Emirates at the end of last year. It is my hope that those environmental gains will be consolidated at the upcoming session of the Conference, to be hosted by Azerbaijan this year, and that industrialized countries will honour their commitments to reduce their emissions and fulfil the pledges they made at the Paris conference in that regard.

We are deeply convinced, in the Islamic Republic of Mauritania, that the effectiveness of cooperation among States depends on relationships based on friendship, trust and mutual respect. Therefore, we have built our foreign policy on non-interference in the internal affairs of States, strengthening cooperation and friendship, the maintenance of international peace and security and support for just causes based on international law, the Charter of the United Nations and the principles of the African Union, the League of Arab States and the Organization of Islamic Cooperation. In that context, we would like to state the following.

We reiterate our strong condemnation of the war of genocide waged by Israel against the defenceless Palestinian people, in flagrant violation of international law and international humanitarian law. We call for an immediate end to that war. We reiterate our commitment to the right of the Palestinian people to dignity and sovereignty within the framework of an independent State, with East Jerusalem as its capital, as provided for in the Arab Peace Initiative and relevant international resolutions. We reiterate our condemnation of the current Israeli attacks on Lebanon and our demand that they be halted immediately.

We reiterate our call to find a solution that preserves the unity and sovereignty of the sisterly Libyan State and renew our commitment to fostering and supporting African and international efforts to that end.

We reiterate our support for the security and stability of the brotherly Sudan and its sovereignty and territorial integrity. We must ensure that dialogue and reason prevail in order to resolve the outstanding issues in a manner that leads to an immediate end of the war and alleviates the suffering of the brotherly Sudanese people while ensuring respect for international humanitarian law.

We reiterate our commitment to genuine efforts to achieve a political solution that preserves the unity of the Syrian Arab Republic, its independence, the dignity of its people and their right to live in peace and security.

We reiterate our support for legitimacy in brotherly Yemen. We call for peaceful solutions, in accordance with Arab initiatives and the relevant international resolutions.

We reiterate our firm position on the conflict in Western Sahara. We support the efforts of the United Nations and the implementation of all relevant Security Council resolutions, with a view to finding a lasting solution that is acceptable to all.

We reiterate our concern about the continuation of the war between Russia and Ukraine and our demand that a solution be found that ends the war and takes into account the concerns of both parties in accordance with international law and the United Nations Charter, thus sparing the region and the world further tragedies and destruction.

The Summit of the Future, which concluded its work yesterday, revealed how aware we are of our collective responsibility towards our common future. Through the measures and plans adopted, the Summit confirmed that we are still able to usher in a future of security, peace, prosperity and comprehensive and sustainable development that will not exclude any population group or country. Let us therefore strengthen mutual trust, intensify our multilateral cooperation and accelerate the reform of international, political and financial governance rules in order to make them more just, balanced and equitable. And then, God willing, we will be able to save our planet from the abyss and secure a bright future for current and future generations.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Islamic Republic of Mauritania for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Mohamed Ould Cheikh El Ghazouani, President of the Islamic Republic of Mauritania, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Sadyr Zhaparov, President of the Kyrgyz Republic

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Kyrgyz Republic.

Mr. Sadyr Zhaparov, President of the Kyrgyz Republic, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Sadyr Zhaparov, President of the Kyrgyz Republic, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

Mr. Zhaparov (*spoke in Kyrgyz; English interpretation provided by the delegation*): I extend my congratulations to the African nations and Mr. Philemon Yang on his election as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. I wish you success in this responsible position and assure you that Kyrgyzstan will provide full support to your presidency in the interests of peace and sustainable development. I also express my gratitude to Mr. Dennis Francis for his active work as President of the General Assembly at its seventy-eighth session.

On behalf of the Kyrgyz Republic, I reaffirm our commitment to international law and the principles and provisions of the Charter of the United Nations, and express our full support for the Organization's efforts to ensure international security; address global social, economic and climate challenges; and protect human rights and freedoms.

Modern global challenges, such as the climate crisis, threats to food security and growing inequality, require the united efforts of the international community. In this

turbulent period, I urge all States to continue to support the United Nations in its core mission — to ensure peace and prevent contemporary risks and threats. Now, more than ever, that support is crucial.

I hope that under the leadership of Secretary-General António Guterres, and with the active support of Member States, our Organization will be able to effectively fulfil its functions and help countries to address pressing global issues.

We live in a world that is becoming increasingly unpredictable and complex every year. We are facing unprecedented challenges — a global climate catastrophe, economic inequality that divides peoples and continents and, of course, conflicts that destroy hope for a peaceful future. We are currently witnessing global military expenditure increases every year, while poor and vulnerable States lack the resources they need for their development and survival.

I would like to draw the Assembly's attention to two conflicting realities of our time.

The first reality is unlimited spending on military needs. According to the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute, in 2023 global military expenditures increased by 6.8 per cent, reaching a record level of \$2.5 trillion per year, or 2.3 per cent of global gross domestic product — the highest amount in decades. Leading Powers are allocating vast resources to creating and developing armed forces, expanding arsenals and developing new, more destructive weapons. Unfortunately, this is happening in a world where many nations and people still lack access to basic services such as water, healthcare and education.

We must ensure that the money spent on war, destruction and death goes to creating common goods or to addressing global challenges for the benefit of humankind, to helping countries in their fight against climate change and to preventing mass displacement and global migration.

Military expenditures and armed conflicts have a devastating effect on many countries, exacerbating poverty and inequality. Conflicts and armed clashes have led to the destruction of infrastructure, a drop in living standards and mass migration, creating a vicious cycle of poverty and instability. While some countries are increasing their military budgets, many of those in need are losing the opportunity for a normal life.

The second reality is the lack of progress in providing aid to poor and vulnerable countries. We all know that economic inequality continues to rise. World leaders have been talking for decades about the need to eliminate poverty, but there is always a lack of willpower. Countries in Africa, South Asia and Latin America continue to face chronic underfunding, a lack of support from the international community and systemic economic crises that cannot be solved by individual countries alone. Countries at the very bottom of the economic pyramid desperately need investment in healthcare, education, infrastructure and climate change mitigation. However, with the rapid growth of military spending, assistance to those countries is becoming increasingly insufficient. Humanitarian aid and development assistance programmes are often underfunded, while resources that could be directed towards social needs are spent on purchasing weapons and conducting military operations. The inequalities between States are not only persisting, but intensifying.

The world faces an important choice. We can continue to increase arms, seeking security through military power, or we can choose the path of sustainable development aimed at eradicating poverty and supporting the most vulnerable. Resources that are spent on military needs could make a huge contribution to addressing global challenges, whether it be access to clean water, education for children in developing countries, fighting famine or financing climate change programmes. To make

progress in that direction, coordinated efforts between the richest and the least developed countries are needed.

First, developed countries must not only increase financial aid to the least developed countries but also focus on targeted infrastructure and social development projects.

Secondly, the least developed countries must actively participate in international sustainable development initiatives and commit to using resources effectively rather than spending them without direction.

Thirdly, the transfer of modern technologies from wealthier countries to poorer ones is crucial, enabling struggling nations to develop their economies independently and reduce dependence on external assistance.

Today we observe that geopolitical conflicts require not only increased defence spending, but, more importantly, international cooperation for their resolution. If the global community can unite its efforts to equitably distribute resources, help vulnerable States and address the root causes of armed conflict, we can build a safer and more prosperous world for all. If we begin to invest in people instead of war — in education, healthcare and sustainable development instead of weapons — we can undoubtedly build a prosperous world. It is time to rethink global security priorities. Security is not merely about powerful armies and weapons of mass destruction. True security is achieved through trust, equality and the prosperity of nations. By investing in the future of the least developed countries, helping them to combat poverty and providing opportunities for sustainable growth, we can create a more stable and secure world.

In that context, I believe that it is crucial and fair for the world community to pay greater attention to the issues of sustainable development in the global South and to champion the interests of the least developed countries, landlocked developing countries and small island developing States.

One of the most dangerous challenges threatening the very existence of our planet is climate change, which is worsening every day and affects almost all countries and peoples worldwide. The accelerated melting of glaciers, the increasing frequency of natural disasters and the reduction of water resources in mountain ecosystems are deeply concerning. These negative consequences threaten the lives of local communities, contribute to rising poverty levels and the deterioration of infrastructure and significantly harm national economies. Kyrgyzstan faces a triple challenge, namely, the need to invest in development, reduce poverty and adapt to climate change in order to achieve carbon neutrality. Each of those areas requires special financing, especially in the context of ensuring climate resilience for our country and vulnerable communities. We are determined to succeed by working together with our partners.

Kyrgyzstan proposes strengthening and globally promoting the debt-for-nature swap mechanism. We believe it will help developing countries and the least developed countries jointly combat climate change. Kyrgyzstan supports the Secretary-General's position on the need to reform the international financial architecture and reduce the debt burden of developing countries. We also propose a mechanism for swapping external debt for climate and sustainable development projects, and we are working to creating a climate trust fund that will finance environmental projects in mountainous regions. The Kyrgyz Republic pays special attention to climate issues in the implementation of its national policy and, based on the principles of green development, has set an ambitious goal of achieving carbon neutrality by 2050. More than 95 per cent of our energy is produced mainly by hydropower plants, which are the main driver towards achieving the goal of net-zero emissions. Our country has extensive opportunities to integrate renewable energy sources into various sectors

of the economy, develop electric transport infrastructure, promote sustainable agriculture and enhance ecotourism. We are taking active measures to stimulate the use of electric vehicles and improve the energy efficiency of buildings.

I would like to give just one example of our commitment to build a green future. We know that projects aimed at sustainable development, such as Neom in Saudi Arabia, Masdar City in United Arab Emirates, Western Harbour in Sweden and Solar Valley in China, are being implemented and successfully developed. The dreams of the peoples of those countries have become a reality and serve as an example for us too. On the shores of Lake Issyk-Kul, we began construction on a modern and innovative city Asman. Next year, we will begin construction of another green city, Kemin. We are striving to build green cities that will serve as a model for other regions of our country, helping to preserve nature for future generations. I am confident that the city will become an economic, trade, cultural and tourist hub and a centre for innovation and new technologies.

Central Asia is becoming an important region for global security and the world economy. Kyrgyzstan, together with neighbouring States, continues to work on the sustainable development of the region. Together with Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan, we are building the Kambar-Ata-1 hydropower plant, which will meet the region's energy and water needs. We are also participating in the construction of the China-Kyrgyzstan-Uzbekistan railway, which will enhance trade and transport cooperation and connect the east and west of the continent.

The future of our world depends on the path we choose. We should not increase military spending, leading to the further escalation of conflicts and disasters. Instead, we must direct our efforts towards building a just, safe and prosperous world for all. Our choice today will determine what tomorrow will be like for future generations. We must all ease international tensions. The Kyrgyz Republic is ready to support the efforts of the General Assembly and the Security Council aimed at establishing a stable world order, achieving the Sustainable Development Goals and making a meaningful contribution to the collective efforts of the international community to address global challenges and threats.

In that regard, we have put forward our candidacy to become a non-permanent member of the Security Council for the 2027–2028 term. As a country that has never been elected to this key United Nations organ, we count on everyone's support in the elections scheduled for June 2026 in New York City. If elected, Kyrgyzstan will continue to work towards enhancing the effectiveness and transparency of the Council's operations and for expanding its composition, taking into account balanced regional representation. It is time to address the lack of representation of African countries in the Council and to correct the historical injustice that 60 Member States, including Kyrgyzstan, have never been elected to the Security Council.

At the Summit of the Future, Member States reaffirmed the importance of the Sustainable Development Goals and the need for their full implementation. Kyrgyzstan remains committed to the global 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, and our achievements confirm our firm intention to achieve the Goals, taking into account national priorities and financial capabilities. The Sustainable Development Goals have been integrated into Kyrgyzstan's national development strategy until 2040, which creates opportunities for sustainable economic and social development, digitalization, entrepreneurship and the introduction of innovative and environmentally friendly technologies for current and future generations. On 22 July, we adopted a law on the protection of rights and funds of private entrepreneurs and foreign investors. That law lays down the necessary measures for protecting investors in business activities. It also prescribes penalties for State officials who, illegally and unjustly, deny State registration or licenses, restrict business activities or interfere in the activities of investors and private entrepreneurs. Those violations

are subject to severe penalties, ranging from two to five years of imprisonment, confiscation of property and substantial fines.

Next year, our country will present its national voluntary review of the implementation of the Sustainable Development Goals. We stand ready to share our experiences, discuss the results and continue striving to be among the 30 countries implementing the Sustainable Development Goals by 2030. As a mountainous country, Kyrgyzstan has drawn global attention to the challenges of sustainable development in mountainous regions. Since the 2000s, at our initiative and with the broad support of mountainous countries, the Five Years of Action for the Development of Mountain Regions is being implemented for the 2023–2027 period. I invite all nations to participate actively in that programme and to take part in the second Global Mountain Summit, Bishkek+25, in 2027, where we will take stock of five years of the mountain regions initiative. In addition, we are promoting the initiative to include global dialogue on mountains and climate on the agenda of the annual United Nations Climate Change Conference.

Kyrgyzstan is actively working to protect the snow leopard — a symbol of long-term sustainable development in the region. In December 2023, the snow leopard was recognized as a national symbol of Kyrgyzstan. Together with 11 other countries that form its habitat, we are working to protect this unique animal. In that connection, I am proud to announce that our draft resolution to designate an international day for the snow leopard will be put before the General Assembly. I urge all nations to support the initiative. The inhabitants of mountainous regions face daily challenges, such as water shortages, food insecurity, poverty and lack of access to basic services. Those countries should not be abandoned with their problems. We call on the international community to take active steps to address those issues.

The time has come for the international community to forge a new consensus on the basis of trust and the interests of all nations. In conclusion, I would like to share the following words from the Epic of Manas, which embody the great depth of friendship, unity and solidarity among peoples: Let us join forces and work together akin to one head on one shoulder and one hand in one sleeve. Where there is unity, there is prosperity.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Kyrgyz Republic for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Sadyr Zhaparov, President of the Kyrgyz Republic, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Javier Gerardo Milei, President of the Argentine Republic

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Argentine Republic.

Mr. Javier Gerardo Milei, President of the Argentine Republic, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Javier Gerardo Milei, President of the Argentine Republic, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Milei (*spoke in Spanish*): Good afternoon to the authorities of the United Nations, to the representatives of its Member States and to all the citizens of the world who are watching us.

For those who do not know, I am not a politician, but a liberal libertarian economist who never harboured any ambition to engage in politics and upon whom was conferred the honour of holding the office of President of the Argentine Republic,

amid the tumultuous failure of more than one century of collectivist policies that ravaged our country.

This is my first address to the General Assembly, and I humbly seize this opportunity to sound a warning to the nations of the world about the path that they have taken for decades and the perils should the Organization fail to discharge its original remit.

I did not come here to tell the world what to do; I came to tell the world what will happen if the United Nations continues to promote the collectivist policies that it has been promoting under the mandate of the Agenda for Sustainable Development and to set out the values that the new Argentina is upholding.

I wish to begin by giving credit where credit is due. The United Nations was born out of the horror of the bloodiest war in history of the world, with the main purpose of ensuring that it would never happen again. To that end, the Organization cast its fundamental principles in stone, in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, which enshrines a fundamental consensus in the maxim that all human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights. Under the stewardship of the Organization and through the adoption of those ideas, over the past 70 years, humankind experienced the longest period of global peace in history, which also coincided with the period of greatest economic growth in history. An international forum was created where nations could settle their disputes through cooperation instead of immediately resorting to weapons, and something inconceivable was achieved: permanently seating the five foremost global Powers around the same table, each vested with an equal power of veto, despite their diametrically opposed interests.

None of that eliminated the scourge of war, but it did ensure that no conflict has — as yet — escalated to a global level. The result was that we went from having two world wars in less than 40 years, which together claimed more than 120 million lives, to enjoying 70 consecutive years of relative global peace and stability, under an order that allowed the entire world to integrate commercially, to compete and to prosper because, as Bastiat put it, where trade enters, bullets do not — because trade guarantees peace, freedom guarantees trade, and equality before the law guarantees liberty. In sum, the words of the Prophet Isaiah that can be read in the park across the street came to pass:

“And He shall judge among the nations, and shall rebuke many people. They shall beat their swords into ploughshares, and their spears into pruning hooks; nation shall not lift up sword against nation, neither shall they learn war anymore.”
(The Holy Bible, Isaiah 2:4)

That is, on the whole, what came to pass under the watch of the United Nations, in its early decades. From that standpoint we are, therefore, talking about a remarkable success in the history of nations and one that cannot be ignored.

At some point, however — as invariably happens with most bureaucratic entities that we humans create — the United Nations ceased upholding the principles set out in its founding declaration and began to alter. An organization that had been conceived, in essence, to serve as a shield to safeguard the kingdom of humankind morphed into a multi-tentacled Leviathan, which seeks to determine not only what each nation State should do, but also how all the world’s citizens should live. We thus went from an organization that pursued peace to one that imposes an ideological agenda on its members in relation to countless issues affecting the life of humans in society. The successful United Nations model, whose origins can be traced back to the ideas of President Wilson and his talk of a society of “peace without victory” and which was founded on the cooperation among nation States, has been jettisoned and replaced by a model of a supranational government of international bureaucrats who seek to impose a specific way of life on the world’s citizens.

What is under discussion this week, here in New York, at the Summit of the Future, is nothing other than the entrenchment of the tragic course that the institution has taken — the entrenchment of a model that, in the words of the Secretary-General himself, requires a new social contract to be defined on a global scale, with a redoubling of the commitments contained in the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. I want to set out clearly Argentina's position on the 2030 Agenda: as well-intentioned as its goals may be, the 2030 Agenda represents nothing more than a socialist supranational government programme that seeks to cure the problems of modernity with solutions that undermine the sovereignty of nation States and violate people's right to life, liberty and property. It is an agenda that seeks to solve poverty, inequality and discrimination with legislation that only entrenches them. World history shows that the only way to guarantee prosperity is by limiting the power of the monarch, guaranteeing equality before the law and defending the right of individuals to life, liberty and property.

It has been precisely the adoption of that agenda, arising from privileged interests and the abandonment of the principles outlined in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, that distorted the role of this institution and put it on the wrong path. Thus, we have seen how an organization born to defend the rights of man has been one of the main proponents of the systematic violation of freedom, as — for example — with the global quarantines during the year 2020, which should be considered a crime against humanity.

The same house that claims to defend human rights, allowed bloody dictatorships, such as that of Cuba and Venezuela, to join the Human Rights Council without the slightest reproach. The same house that claims to defend women's rights, allows countries that punish their women for showing their skin to join the Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women. This same house has systematically voted against the State of Israel, the only country in the Middle East that defends liberal democracy, while simultaneously demonstrating a total inability to respond to the scourge of terrorism.

In the economic sphere, collectivist policies have been promoted that threaten economic growth, violate property rights and hinder the natural economic process, preventing the most underprivileged countries in the world from freely enjoying their own resources in order to move forward, with regulations and prohibitions promoted precisely by the countries that became developed through the same activities they condemn today. Moreover, a toxic relationship has been promoted between global governance policies and international lending agencies, requiring the most neglected countries to commit resources they do not have to programmes they do not need, turning them into perpetual debtors to promote the agenda of the global elites.

Nor has the tutelage of the World Economic Forum helped, where ridiculous policies are promoted with Malthusian blinders, such as zero-emission policies, which harm poor countries in particular, and policies linked to sexual and reproductive rights, when the birth rate in Western countries is plummeting, heralding a bleak future for all. Nor has the Organization satisfactorily fulfilled its mission of defending the territorial sovereignty of its members, as we Argentines know first-hand, in regard to the Malvinas Islands. And we have even reached a situation in which the Security Council, the most important organ of this house, has become distorted because the veto of its permanent members has begun to be used in defence of the particular interests of some.

As a result, our Organization today is powerless to provide solutions to real global conflicts, such as the aberrant Russian invasion of Ukraine, which has already cost the lives of more than 300,000 people, leaving a trail of more than 1 million wounded in the process. Instead of confronting those conflicts, this Organization invests time and effort in imposing on poor countries what and how they should

produce, with whom they should associate, what they should eat and what they should believe in, as the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) seeks to dictate. This long list of errors and contradictions has not been gratuitous but has resulted in the loss of credibility of the United Nations in the eyes of the citizens of the free world and in the distortion of its functions.

Therefore, I would like to issue a warning — we are at the end of a cycle. The collectivism and moral posturing of the woke agenda have collided with reality and no longer have credible solutions to offer to the world's real problems. In fact, they never did. If the 2030 Agenda failed — as its own promoters acknowledge — the response should be to ask ourselves if it was not, from the start, an ill-conceived programme, to accept that reality and to change course. We cannot seek to perpetuate that mistake by doubling down on an agenda that has failed. The same thing always happens with ideas from the left, which designs a model according to what human beings should be — according to them — and when individuals freely act otherwise, they have no better solution than to restrict, repress and restrict their freedom.

We in Argentina have already seen with our own eyes what lies at the end of this road of envy and sad passions — poverty, brutalization, anarchy and a fatal absence of freedom. We still have time to turn away from that course.

I want to be clear about something so that there are no misinterpretations. Argentina, which is undergoing a profound process of change, has decided to embrace the ideas of freedom; those ideas that maintain that all citizens are born free and equal before the law, that we have inalienable rights granted by the Creator, among which are the right to life, liberty and property. Those principles, which guide the process of change that we are carrying out in Argentina, are also the principles that will guide our international conduct from now on.

We believe in the defence of life for all; we believe in the defence of property for all; we believe in freedom of speech for all; we believe in freedom of worship for all; we believe in freedom of commerce for all; and we believe in limited Governments, all of them.

And because in these times what happens in one country quickly impacts others, we believe that all peoples should live free from tyranny and oppression, whether it takes the form of political oppression, economic slavery or religious fanaticism. That fundamental idea must not remain mere words; it must be supported in deeds — diplomatically, economically and materially — through the combined strength of all countries that stand for freedom.

This doctrine of the new Argentina is no more and no less than the true essence of the United Nations Organization, that is, the cooperation of the nations united in defence of freedom. If the United Nations decides to retake the principles that gave it life and to adapt again the role for which it was conceived, it can count on the unwavering support of Argentina in the struggle for freedom.

States should also know that Argentina will not support any policy that implies the restriction of individual freedoms, of trade, or the violation of the natural rights of individuals, no matter who promotes it or how much consensus that institution enjoys. For that reason, we wish to officially express our dissent with regard to the Pact for the Future, signed on Sunday, and we invite all the nations of the free world to join us, not only in rejecting that Pact, but also in the creation of a new agenda for this noble institution: an agenda of freedom.

From this day on, know that the Argentine Republic will abandon the position of historical neutrality that characterized us and will be at the forefront of the struggle in defence of freedom because, as Thomas Paine said, “those who expect to reap the blessings of freedom, must, like men, undergo the fatigue of supporting it”.

May God bless the Argentinian people and all the citizens of the world, and may the forces of heaven be with us.

Long live freedom, damn it!

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Argentine Republic for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Javier Gerardo Milei, President of the Argentine Republic, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Nayib Armando Bukele, President of the Republic of El Salvador

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of El Salvador.

Mr. Nayib Armando Bukele, President of the Republic of El Salvador, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Nayib Armando Bukele, President of the Republic of El Salvador, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Bukele (*spoke in Spanish*): When I first came to the General Assembly in 2019, I know that many people did not know El Salvador or had never even heard of El Salvador — and if they had, it was only for negative reasons, as either the most violent country or the country of gangs. Others did not even know where to find it on the map. But, thank God, that has changed significantly, and in a very short time. Five years after that first address (see A/74/PV.7), I come here as the President of a country that now has a voice in the world. In my previous addresses to the General Assembly, I spoke about the quest for our true independence. For decades we were shackled by the consequences of an imported civil war and then by a false peace that left more dead than the war itself.

I also spoke of the importance of remembering that a government's first responsibility is to its own people and underlined that taking our destiny into our own hands was essential. We were naive to think that other countries would save us or give us our freedom out of simple kindness. We had to understand those things in order to find the courage to break our chains ourselves and claim our legitimate right to be free.

In the last five years, El Salvador has been reborn. We gave the streets of our country back to our people and established a thriving tourism industry, hosting international surfing, sports and entertainment events. We gave thousands of Salvadorans who fled wars and poverty a country to return to. We made our nation, once the homicide capital of the world, the safest country in the entire Western hemisphere. It was the greatest challenge our nation has ever overcome, and although we still have a long way to go and there are still many things to accomplish, we are within reach of true independence and on the road to full freedom. El Salvador's transformation is unparalleled, and our success is undeniable. Anyone can visit El Salvador and see for themselves. Salvadorans, regardless of who they voted for, regardless of the town or city where they were born, regardless of how much or how little they have, regardless of whether they are inside or outside our borders, have united to work and support each of our decisions, each of which has allowed El Salvador to be a country where people can live in peace and happiness, where spiritual aspirations, beyond material ones, are within everyone's reach.

Today the world considers the example of El Salvador and wonders, how can a nation lift itself up in such a short amount of time? But perhaps that is not the

question they should be asking. Maybe they should be asking how it is that the world is collapsing so fast.

It is said that El Salvador is swimming against the tide, because, as El Salvador has become safer, the world has become less safe. While the Salvadoran people are becoming more optimistic, most people in the modern world are becoming increasingly pessimistic. And, yes, they are right: the world has become divided, depressed, worried, hostile and hopeless, and it has done so at an unprecedented speed.

Today the free world is no longer free, and that is no exaggeration. Tragically we see undeniable evidence of the decline every day. New threats of wars are ongoing. When the free world became free it was because of its principles of freedom of speech, equality before the law, unity and respect for private property. But once a nation abandons the principles that make it free, it is only a matter of time before it loses its freedom altogether.

The consequences are unfolding before our very eyes. We can see it. In some so-called first-world cities, stores need to secure their products behind locked glass doors to prevent theft. I am not even talking about expensive products, but simple things like a chocolate bar or a razor. In other cities, the streets no longer belong to the people but have fallen into the hands of homeless people and gangs and become the domain of organized crime and drugs. One cannot claim to be the free world, if one's people are not free to walk the streets without the fear of being harassed, robbed or killed.

We are also witnessing in real time the erosion of freedom of expression. Just a decade ago, the West was the bastion of free speech but today is being called out by those it used to denounce. At the request of their governments, the world's largest social media platforms have been forced to censor their users. Citizens of Western countries have been arrested for sharing posts on social media. Ruling parties have attempted to ban their political opposition. These are not accusations or conspiracy theories; they are verifiable and widely documented facts.

The respect of the people cannot be won without respecting the people. This development is not new, but we notice it more now because in recent years it has accelerated, which means that we are approaching a dangerous turning point: we are facing a new dark age for humankind. Salvadorans recognize the symptoms of decadence when we see them because we have been through them all. We lived through the stages of our nation's downfall one by one, and we are seeing those same stages once again, but now on a global scale.

We cannot and do not want to tell other countries what to do. Each country must make its own decisions and do what is best for its people. We can only offer a word of caution from a friend who has been through a dark period himself and fought the battle of his life to get out of it.

We cannot change the course of the world. El Salvador is too small a country to do that. We are in fact the smallest country in all of the Americas. This situation is much bigger than us, and in truth it is bigger than any nation. We cannot prevent the dark times ahead, but what we can do is become a small shelter from the coming storm and maintain hope.

In El Salvador we do not imprison our opposition or censor opinion, nor do we confiscate the property of those who think differently. We do not arrest people for expressing their ideas. In El Salvador, one's freedom of expression and one's private property will always be protected. In El Salvador we prioritize the safety of our honest citizens over the comfort of criminals. Some say that we have imprisoned thousands, but the reality is that we have freed millions. Now it is the good guys who live free and without fear, with their freedoms and human rights fully respected.

We want our people to prosper, which is why we foster innovation and encourage new ideas. We understand that safe and free spaces are needed for invention to flourish. Creative ideas should be investigated, tested and experimented with; they should not be stifled by outdated regulations or fear of change.

In El Salvador people will find spaces to pursue their ambitions, whether in technology, finance, energy, medicine, the arts, culture, music or architecture. A few years ago, El Salvador was one of the darkest places on the planet. But in a short time our nation has been reborn, and that is because we reminded ourselves that freedom is taken hold of. It is not a gift, nor is it given away, and, like everything in life worth having, it needs care and maintenance.

Today El Salvador is a country safe for progress and innovation, as well as for families and for individual pursuit. In the new El Salvador everyone has a place. We offer this safe space primarily for our people, but it is also for those who wish to share in and contribute to our vision.

It will not be easy. In fact, it is possible that the next step will be more difficult than the previous one. We have liberated our country, but we must preserve that freedom and do so in a world that is increasingly less free. El Salvador has left behind its past, to which it vows never to return. It may be too late to avoid the dark times facing our world today, but it is not too late to build an ark and weather the storm. May God bless humankind.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of El Salvador for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Nayib Armando Bukele, President of the Republic of El Salvador, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Masoud Pezeshkian, President of the Islamic Republic of Iran

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Islamic Republic of Iran.

Mr. Masoud Pezeshkian, President of the Islamic Republic of Iran, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Masoud Pezeshkian, President of the Islamic Republic of Iran, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Pezeshkian (*spoke in Farsi, English interpretation provided by the delegation*): I extend my sincere congratulations both to the General Assembly on the opening of its general debate at its seventy-ninth session and to the President of the Assembly on his well-deserved election to that post. I trust that the crucial themes of this session — peace, sustainable development and human dignity — will illuminate a bright path for both present and future generations.

Last year, the devoted late president of my country, Mr. Seyyed Ebrahim Raisi, addressed the General Assembly from this very rostrum (see A/78/PV.5). He was martyred in the service of the Iranian people. May his soul rest in peace.

This is my first time addressing the Assembly as the president of the Islamic Republic of Iran, a position I assumed after the Iranian people voted in favour of my central campaign platform of national empathy. This guiding principle is rooted in the command of Almighty God, as set forth in the Holy Qur'an.

According to the teachings of the Qur'an, humankind had once been a single community, to whom Allah sent prophets as heralds and as warners to reveal truth through Scripture to help judge the disputes among people. No one disputed the

Scriptures except the very people who received them — out of jealousy — despite the clear proofs they had received.

Imam Ali instructed one of his governors to embrace people with all his heart, show them kindness, extend his compassion towards them, and refuse to treat those under his command with harshness or violence. For people fall into two categories: they are either one's brothers in religion or equals in creation.

The mission of all prophets has been to establish and promote truth and justice in society among all peoples, regardless of colour, race, gender or language. Peace and security in the world will not be achieved unless the rights of all individuals, communities and nations are upheld with justice and fairness.

Let us ask ourselves, are the roots of war and bloodshed we see in today's world anything other than the fact that aggressors have violated the rights of others, overlooked the rights of nations, enforced discrimination and inequality, kept certain groups weak and underdeveloped, and disregarded the rights of individuals? As long as injustice, oppression, greed, poverty and ignorance prevail in any region, violence and conflict will continue. Unless we confront the root causes of such disorders, we cannot rescue the future of our children from darkness and destruction.

I embarked on my electoral campaign with a platform focused on reform, national empathy, constructive engagement with the world, and economic development. I was honoured to gain the trust of my fellow citizens at the ballot box. I aim to lay a strong foundation for my country's entry into a new era, positioning it to play an effective and constructive role in the evolving global order. My objective is to address existing obstacles and challenges while structuring my country's foreign relations, in cognizance of the necessities and realities of the contemporary world.

Over the past year, the world has witnessed the true nature of the Israeli regime. It has witnessed how the regime carries out atrocities in Gaza. In 11 months, it has murdered in cold blood over 41,000 innocent people, mostly women and children. Its leaders label this genocide — the killing of children, war crimes and State terrorism — as legitimate self-defence. They call hospitals, kindergartens and schools as legitimate military targets. They consider the freedom-loving and brave people around the world who protest against their genocide to be anti-Semitic. They designate and oppress people who have stood up against seven decades of occupation and humiliation as terrorists. Israel has assassinated Iranian scientists, diplomats and even guests on our soil, and it has supported both overtly and covertly such terrorist groups as the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant.

In contrast, Iran has supported popular liberation movements of people that have been victims of four generations of the crimes and colonialism of the Israeli regime. We have been siding with the people across the world who have flooded the streets in outrage against Israeli atrocities. We condemn Israeli crimes against humanity.

It is imperative that the international community immediately stop the violence and bring about a permanent ceasefire in Gaza and end the desperate barbarism of Israel in Lebanon before it engulfs the region and the world. Israel has been defeated in Gaza, and no amount of barbaric violence can restore its myth of invincibility.

Naturally, blind Israeli State terrorism over the past few days in Lebanon, followed by a massive aggression causing thousands of victims, cannot go unanswered. The responsibility for all consequences will be borne by those governments that have thwarted all global efforts to end this horrific catastrophe and have the audacity to call themselves champions of human rights.

The only path to end the 70-year-old nightmare in West Asia and the world is to restore the right of all Palestinians to self-determination. We propose that all people of Palestine, both those who live in their motherland and those who have been forced

into its diaspora, determine their future in a referendum. We are confident that through such a mechanism we can achieve a lasting peace with Muslims, Christians and Jews living side by side with one another in one land, in tranquillity and peace and away from racism and apartheid.

When we examine the contemporary history of the region, we see that Iran has never initiated a war. It has only heroically defended itself against external aggression, causing the aggressors to regret their actions. Iran has never occupied the territory of any nation, nor has it sought the resources of any country. It has repeatedly offered various proposals to its neighbours and in international forums aimed at establishing lasting peace and stability.

We have emphasized the importance of unity in the region and of establishing a strong region that rests on several fundamental principles. First, we must recognize that we are neighbours who, because of this bond, will always remain together. The presence of foreign Powers in our region has always been temporary and led to instability. Our development and progress are interconnected, and outsourcing security to extraregional Powers will not benefit any of us.

Secondly, the new regional order must be inclusive and beneficial for all neighbours. An order that fails to safeguard the interests of each neighbouring country cannot be sustained.

Thirdly, neighbouring and brotherly countries should not waste their valuable resources on attritional rivalries and arms races. Our region suffers from war, sectarian tensions, terrorism and extremism, drug trafficking, water scarcity, refugee crises, environmental degradation and foreign intervention. The way to address these shared challenges — in order to ensure a better future for coming generations — is through collective effort.

I am the president of a country that throughout modern history has endured threats, war, occupation and sanctions. Others have neither come to our assistance nor respected our declared neutrality. Global Powers have even sided with aggressors against us. We have learned that we can only rely on our own people and our own native capabilities.

The Islamic Republic of Iran seeks to safeguard its own security, not to create insecurity for others. We want peace for all and seek no war or quarrel with anyone.

We seek lasting peace and security for the peoples of Ukraine and Russia. The Islamic Republic of Iran opposes war and emphasizes the urgent need to end military hostilities in Ukraine. We support all peaceful solutions and believe that dialogue is the only way to resolve this crisis.

In the current globalized world, the security and interests of a country cannot be attained by undermining the security and interests of others. We need a new paradigm to address global challenges. Such a paradigm must focus on opportunities instead of being obsessed with perceived threats. Such an approach, based on engagement, can provide us with fresh opportunities for cooperation.

Iran and global Powers achieved a historic nuclear deal in 2015, the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), through that fresh outlook, based on shared opportunities. Iran agreed to an unprecedented level of nuclear oversight — the highest ever — in return for recognition of our rights and the lifting of sanctions within the JCPOA framework. Trump's unilateral withdrawal from that agreement manifested a political approach laced with threats and an economic strategy driven by coercion.

Unilateral sanctions target innocent people and seek to undermine the foundations of the Iranian economy. The goal is to "securitize" Iran, which, experience shows,

leads to insecurity for all. The so-called maximum-pressure policy of the United States was in fact implemented against the Iranian people when Iran was fulfilling all its obligations under the JCPOA, as was repeatedly verified by the International Atomic Energy Agency.

We are ready to engage with JCPOA participants, if JCPOA commitments are implemented fully and in good faith. Dialogue on other issues can follow. In this context, I want to address the American people: It is not Iran that has established military bases along United States borders. It is not Iran that has imposed sanctions on the United States and obstructed its trade relations with the world. It is not Iran that prevents Americans from gaining access to medicine. It is not Iran that has restricted access to the global banking and financial system. We have not targeted United States military leaders; rather, it is the United States that assassinated Iran's most revered military commander at the Baghdad airport.

My message to all States pursuing a counterproductive strategy towards Iran is to learn from history. We have the opportunity to transcend these limitations and enter a new era. This era will commence with the acknowledgment of Iran's security concerns and with cooperation on mutual challenges.

Sanctions are destructive and inhumane weapons designed to cripple a nation's economy. Preventing access to essential medications is one of the most painful consequences of sanctions, endangering the lives of thousands of innocent people. Not only are such measures a blatant violation of human rights, but they also constitute a crime against humanity.

Our nation has demonstrated resilience in the face of numerous hardships caused by sanctions over the past few years. Although the wounds inflicted by these sanctions are deep within our society, confronting this bitter experience has transformed us into a stronger nation with unwavering resolve and self-confidence.

In order to build a better world in future, Iran stands prepared to foster meaningful economic, social, political and security partnerships with global Powers and its neighbours based on equal footing with them. The appropriate response to this message from Iran is not to impose more sanctions, but to fulfil existing obligations to remove sanctions, for the benefit of the Iranian people, thereby laying the foundations for more constructive agreements. I hope that this message from Iran today is receives the close attention it deserves.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Islamic Republic of Iran for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Masoud Pezeshkian, President of the Islamic Republic of Iran, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Alar Karis, President of the Republic of Estonia

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Estonia.

Mr. Alar Karis, President of the Republic of Estonia, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Alar Karis, President of the Republic of Estonia, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Karis: I want to live in a world that is at peace, in a world that is not destroying itself, where proud sovereign nations, large or small, old or young, modern or traditional, are not conquered and colonized. I want to live in a world where everybody can feel free, where artificial intelligence serves rather than

hinders humanity and where nobody has to fear oppression based on gender, race, nation, beliefs or one's thoughts. I want to live in a world that is fit for freedom because freedom paves the way for lasting solutions and prosperity, and because freedom is the core of humanity.

Do we all not want this too? Regrettably, peace and freedom are under threat. The latest survey by Freedom House, in 2023, proved that global freedom declined for the eighteenth consecutive year. The number of those countries where political rights and civil liberties are diminishing is more than twice the number of those countries where rights, liberties and freedom are improving.

Unfortunately, peace and freedom are words that are blatantly misused. Too often we see that the one promising peace and freedom brings oppression and suffering instead. The weaker the mechanisms we have to protect international law, the bigger the threat to the way most of us want to live. We may keep condemning brutal acts of violence, and we may even strongly condemn atrocities, but without effective acts to counter violence, history will condemn us, and it will condemn us strongly.

But it is not our place in history that we have to worry about. Something else keeps us awake at night: the children whom we have lost to conflicts, who will not live long enough to see a high school diploma, who will never have the chance to learn how to ride a bike, who will never dance in the desert, who will not be free, who will not be sharing a smile.

The happiness of a child is priceless. The image of a happy child should cause us to correct our moral compass — personally, globally, strategically and tactically. The image of a happy child will come to life everywhere in the world — on the shores of the Gulf of Aden, the Azov Sea, the Bay of Bengal, the Dead Sea, the Caspian Sea, Lake Tanganyika, the Yellow Sea — when the universally shared rules prevail, when international law is respected, when the United Nations Charter is applied.

We therefore have no option other than to adjust the United Nations system so that it lives up to the demands and necessities of the twenty-first century. That means reinforcing the United Nations Charter. Restoring the credibility of the United Nations and reforming the Organization should grant a better and more efficient application of the Charter so that peace and security is maintained in everyone's interest and everywhere in the world.

The need to reform the United Nations and its Security Council has been discussed for decades. I am convinced that, now more than ever, the renewal and strengthening of the multilateral world order with the United Nations Charter at its core is in the interest of all of us.

The Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1), which we adopted at the Summit of the Future just a few days ago (see A/79/PV.3), is a good start. It can guide us on the way forward. We must now implement all that we have pledged in the Pact. In fact, we should have been even more ambitious.

The Security Council of the future has to be fit for purpose, efficient, transparent, open and accountable, with strengthened decision-making capacity. The Council's composition must adequately reflect the current world. It must also be inclusive in conducting its business to better respond to the current global threats.

But there is no easy formula for how to do that. Otherwise, we would already have a balanced, agile and effective Security Council in place. One thing is certain — and this is also acknowledged in the Pact for the Future — the scope and use of the veto right must be limited. Estonia supports all efforts to limit the use of the veto, especially with regard to actions aimed at ending or preventing mass atrocities. Currently the veto right in the Security Council gives its holder a great power, which

can also bring finding solutions to a standstill, especially when a solution sharply conflicts with the interests of the veto-holding member.

Deadlocks of the Security Council can be measured directly in lost and crippled human lives, which is not right and wholly unacceptable. We believe that all States collectively should have a bigger say in maintaining peace and security than one member of the Security Council, especially in the case of a deadlock in the Council.

We cannot restore the credibility of the multilateral system and the United Nations when a permanent member of the Security Council acts against the principles of the Charter. Let us therefore wisely use the powers of the General Assembly. We, in the General Assembly, should be able to collectively overcome the veto in the Security Council if the situation requires it. Let us analyse the options for how the General Assembly could gain more prominence. In addition, I recommend taking this analysis to our capitals and to different conferences around the world in order to gather new ideas in an inclusive global debate.

The Pact for the Future acknowledges the need for revitalizing the work of General Assembly, also in terms of strengthening coordination with the Security Council, which, *inter alia*, would mean that future peace operations could better respond to existing challenges and emerging realities. The precision and sharpness of the Pact for the Future allows us to believe that the United Nations 2.0 is an idea that could meet the current challenges on the ground.

The pain of losing a person close to us is grave. It hurts us no matter where it happens. Life will never be the same after such a tragedy. Russia's aggression against Ukraine causes inhumane suffering, as do the war in Gaza, the worsening fighting in the Sudan, the tensions, instability, human rights violations in the Sahel, the war in Syria, the unresolved Rohingya crisis, the humanitarian catastrophe in Yemen and the suppression and torture of girls and women in Afghanistan.

Since the horrific terrorist attacks by Hamas against Israel almost a year ago, there has been too much suffering in Gaza and the region. The destruction, loss of life and trauma is unimaginable and only leads to a vicious cycle of violence and deepening hatred. We believe it is high time for an agreement that would establish a ceasefire and allow for the release of hostages.

Without being naive or blind to regional complexity, Estonia is deeply convinced that the two-State solution is the only way to a just and lasting peace. Israelis and Palestinians each deserve to live in a free, sovereign country, within secure and recognized borders. We must step up our efforts to achieve this goal.

In this very Hall, the global community has condemned Russia's aggression against Ukraine (resolution ES-11/1). Russia has attacked international peace and security and as well as the United Nations Charter. That is a fact confirmed by the General Assembly. We must also firmly condemn the actions of those that arm Russia in this aggression — Iran and North Korea.

It has been becoming increasingly important not to lose sight of the truth of the situation. We cannot and we will not accept the blurring of realities on the ground. Russia's war against Ukraine is a clear black-and-white situation. Russia is the aggressor, and Ukraine is the victim.

Russian violations against international law are brutal and widely documented. Russia has systematically killed civilians. Ukrainian children are deported to camps far away from their homes and parents, supposedly to teach them how to think correctly. Unfortunately sending people to so-called correction camps where they are taught "correct" behaviour patterns are without precedent in today's world. It makes me wonder in which century we actually live.

What would any of us do if the aggressor, the murderer of our parents, stood in front of us? Would we demand justice, accountability and the end of aggressive behaviour? Or would we call the aggressor for a chat to settle misunderstandings between us?

Deplorably the smooth talk about dialogue and the importance of Ukraine and Russia engaging in direct peace talks is only supporting the Russian cause, especially when the so-called peace proposals fail to recognize which party launched the aggression and which party is actually bearing the brunt of the suffering.

We are not going to call Russia to have a coffee. Instead, we call on the Russians to accept President Zelenskyy's 10-point peace formula, which has wide international support. Russia must end the aggression and withdraw its troops and military equipment from the territory of Ukraine. Ukraine's territorial integrity and sovereignty must be restored. We demand that Russia stop its cynical and shameless exploitation of various conflicts to its own advantage. By fuelling contradictions in Africa, Europe, America or elsewhere, Russia attacks the coherence of our societies and generates instability.

Misinformation is a widely used weapon for that purpose. We have to act decisively to counter the systematic spread of lies. To succeed in this, we must develop critical thinking and knowledge. That is why providing universal education across the world is so strategically important.

While drafting United Nations resolutions we must consider the new mechanisms that are being weaponized to undermine international peace and security. The world has changed. Information is rushing out in various digital formats, and we tend to live in fragmented bubbles, which, in turn, can create fertile ground for extremist terrorist groups or neo-imperial expansionist ambitions. Similarly, refugees are sometimes used as pawns in actions designed to destabilize.

Our changing world poses new challenges. Let us make sure that the methods, agencies and resolutions used by the United Nations meet the requirements of the twenty-first century.

Last year Estonia proposed the Fit for Freedom agenda that calls for a global discussion, first, on how to reinforce multilateralism and the international rules-based system with the United Nations Charter at its core; secondly, on how to foster decision-making that includes all States and societies; and thirdly, on how to ensure human rights and freedoms for all.

The central idea of Fit for Freedom is simple: international law must be upheld, and the rules must be applied. Only then are we all better off. We do not need a global cataclysm to build something instead of the United Nations. We have learned from the past and are able to build on the structures of the United Nations already in place. What it takes most of all to succeed is political will.

The possibilities to engage with the work of the Security Council and its subsidiary organs should be expanded to include all the members of the General Assembly. With the specific help from technology, the Security Council's accountability must be enhanced. If the working culture were more open, hypocrisy and lies would indeed have shorter legs. Promoting new, open and swift-acting models of work and administration is the second pillar on how we can make the world freer.

This year Estonia chairs the Media Freedom Coalition, and next year it will chair the Freedom Online Coalition. We will build on the conviction that fundamental freedoms and human rights should be the mainstay of international politics, even more forcefully and consciously than they have been before today. If fundamental human rights are protected, then we may conclude that international law and the

United Nations Charter will not only be maintained, but they will be strengthened. When international rules apply to everyone, the world is fit for freedom.

Positive change is possible. Estonia's own story is a perfect illustration of that. We have built a digital, cybersecure society where citizens feel that they themselves are the State, which is as it should be. We know from our own experience that freedom combined with the proper technology and an innovation-oriented mindset are the best tools for finding long-term solutions. It is true that free societies might also need some updates from time to time, and the latest plug-ins should be optimized for user-friendly performance. That is so because, if maintained properly, they do not crash and freeze the way autocracies tend to do.

Estonians have a vivid memory of the times when human rights were denied to us. This makes Estonia vigorous in standing up for those fighting for their rights today. We partner with those who have reached out for a helping hand to enhance children's access to education and medicine. We unite with those who work tirelessly to grant women and girls equal rights with men and boys. And we are aligned with all who follow the principles of the universality and indivisibility of human rights. My country stands for these principles as a candidate for the Human Rights Council for the term 2026 to 2028.

What kind of change are we going to see? We know the answer. It is up to us to reform the United Nations so that it can safeguard international peace and security and build a world fit for freedom. Let us get to work and do something about that.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Estonia for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Alar Karis, President of the Republic of Estonia, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Gabriel Boric Font, President of the Republic of Chile

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Chile.

Mr. Gabriel Boric Font, President of the Republic of Chile, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Gabriel Boric Font, President of the Republic of Chile, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Boric Font (*spoke in Spanish*): The year 2025 will mark 80 years since 51 countries took the momentous step of creating the United Nations. Our country, Chile, has always been a proud part of this collective effort. We were one of the founding countries, and today, almost 80 years later, we continue to defend democracy, peace, multilateralism and full respect for human rights.

Since 1945, the world has greatly changed. It must have been complex then — full of hope because the war had ended, but torn by the poverty, destruction and death the war left in its wake. Still scarred in 1945 by the disgrace of colonialism, the inexorable emancipation of peoples from their colonizers was already beginning to bubble up.

Once again, a great deal of time has passed since 1945, and the world has changed radically. Imagine if a 20-year-old from that era were to magically awaken in 2024. Surely, he or she would not be able to believe what he or she was seeing.

The world has changed, but some things have remained the same. An example of that, which is often cited from this rostrum, is the United Nations Security Council. Yet the world of 2024 is not the world of 1945.

I listened attentively this morning to Secretary-General António Guterres, President Lula da Silva of Brazil and President Biden of the United States of America explicitly express their agreement that the Council should be reformed in accordance with today's times (see A/79/PV.7). Who or what is preventing this? Is there anyone in this Assembly who opposes such reform?

Chile proposes that we set a deadline for reform and that by the time the United Nations turns 80, it has a Security Council in keeping with the times, and that Brazil from Latin America, India, at least one African country, among others, play an important part. There is nothing to prevent that, except our lack of will. Human institutions depend on the will of their leaders — us — and those that are unable to adapt to their times run the risk of collapse. We need only recall the rapid collapse of the League of Nations. There are times when change is the best way to ensure the continuity of our history, and this is precisely one of those times.

The same goes for financial governance. We value the efforts undertaken by global financial institutions to modernize, but Chile supports, above all, the Nigeria-led African proposal to address tax evasion, illicit financial flows and inequalities in tax collection through the establishment of a convention on international tax cooperation, in order to achieve a more transparent and inclusive system, with a global tax system that supports the financing of the fight against the climate crisis, whereby countries and large corporations as well are held accountable for their financial transactions and contribute their fair share to the countries from which they have derived their wealth.

To meet these challenges and many others, I have no doubt that it is the possible leadership of a woman, as we agreed in the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) adopted on a few days ago (see A/79/PV.3), coming from our Americas, in accordance with the United Nations territorial rotation criteria, that could guide this process by following the reformist path undertaken by António Guterres.

At times, the international community is accused of double standards in the face of human rights violations occurring in one part of the world or another. What the adversary does is condemned, but when a supposed friend or someone of the same political colour is the one who violates the United Nations Charter, ambiguity reigns.

Chile rejects double standards when it comes to human rights. As a young leftist Latin American president, I say loud and clear that human rights must be respected always and everywhere, and we must demand this respect regardless of the political colour of the dictator or president in office who violates such rights. Indeed, the Palestinian teenager murdered in Gaza, the Venezuelan worker forced to migrate from his homeland, the Ukrainian child kidnapped by Russia, the opponent silenced in Nicaragua, and the woman expelled from school in Afghanistan just for being a woman, are first and foremost human beings, and the voice of all nations, regardless of their political orientation, must be raised to defend them. That is the principled position that we in Chile support, beyond any geopolitical interest.

I therefore refuse to choose between Hamas' terrorism or Netanyahu's Israel's massacres that lead to genocide. We do not have to choose between forms of savagery; I choose humanity.

We denounce the illegal occupation of the Palestinian territories and the de facto denial of the existence of an independent Palestinian State by the occupying country. Chile calls for an immediate ceasefire in Gaza to put an end to the suffering and massacre of the Palestinian population that has already claimed more than 40,000

lives. Imagine all the wounded. We also clearly and unambiguously demand the immediate release of the hostages currently held by the terrorist group Hamas.

In this Hall today, we wish to point out that Israel must respect international law, cease the establishment and expansion of illegal settlements in occupied Palestinian territory, and end the massacre in Gaza and the indiscriminate attacks it has been carrying out on the civilian population. As has consistently been the policy of Chile, we insist once again on the need to reach a two-State solution with defined, secure and internationally recognized borders, in accordance with the 1967 borders.

Furthermore, Russia's aggression against Ukraine must stop. It is the United Nations that is called upon to put an end to this flagrant transgression of international law. We cannot accept that it is natural for one country to invade another and take over part of its territory. For medium-sized countries such as ours, demanding respect for international law is the main guarantee we have that our own sovereignty and our own territorial integrity will be respected.

Today, from this rostrum, I would like to place particular emphasis on the situation of the Ukrainian children kidnapped by Russia and taken to its territory. These children must be returned to their families.

Before this Assembly, Chile reaffirms its commitment to democracy as the only system capable of maintaining peace, achieving sustainable development and protecting the dignity, rights and fundamental freedoms of people. We therefore view with concern the growing disaffection of citizens everywhere for this form of government, including our own country. We also look with concern at the emergence of authoritarian leaders who persecute or insult those who disagree with them. It is our duty to speak out and combat those who erode democracy, whether by authoritarianism or by shamelessly spreading fake news. At the same time, we must be able to respond to the needs and distress of our citizens in order to restore their confidence in democratic institutions and mechanisms.

We see with concern how these threats loom over our region. Chile will continue to make efforts to build bridges between diverse societies and call for integrating the voices of Latin America and the world in order to promoting peace and stability, as we recently did with the President of the Government of Spain and the President of Brazil at the summit of progressive leaders. Such an approach does not prevent us from harshly condemning any violation of human rights, international law or attacks against democracy in sister countries.

Chile is particularly aware of the critical situation in Venezuela. We are facing a dictatorship that has intended to steal an election, persecutes its opponents and is indifferent to the exile, not of thousands, but of millions, of its citizens. What is needed to end this crisis is a political solution that recognizes that the opposition won the most recent elections and leads to a peaceful transition to a proper democracy.

At the same time, I must say that the unilateral sanctions imposed by the United States, referred to this morning by President Biden (see A/79/PV.7), are not helpful in solving the conflict; on the contrary, they worsen it. Economic sanctions are hitting the Venezuelan people harder than they are hitting the country's current rulers, harming both the poor and workers, because the political crisis has been combined with an economic crisis. Together they have pushed more than 7 million — I repeat, 7 million — Venezuelans into exile outside their country, of whom approximately 800,000 are in Chile. It is my responsibility to be clear in this regard: Chile is not in a position to receive more migrants. We call on United States authorities to lift economic sanctions, which we in the South know bring only greater poverty to the people — and not to the dictators.

None of us, not even the most powerful, can face such phenomena as the climate crisis, pandemics, the digital revolution or transnational organized crime alone. We need each other. We also need the United Nations and a stronger, more active international community. This is the vision that we have promoted in our participation in the various bodies of the United Nations system. I would like in particular to highlight Chile's presidency of the Economic and Social Council from July 2023 to July 2024, under the leadership of our Permanent Representative to the United Nations, Mrs. Paula Narváez Ojeda.

I also speak for all my fellow compatriots when I express before this Assembly our worry and concern about the increase in transnational organized crime and its devastating effects on the security and development of countries, and on democracy and people's lives. It is essential that our governments act in a coordinated manner and craft public policies, strategies and operational capacity to help stop the financial, drug trafficking, human trafficking and arms trafficking crimes that affect our countries.

Security is the main concern of the majority of the Chilean people today; it is also the main concern in Latin America in general. States cannot surrender to or normalize violence and organized crime. They must stand firm against crime and corruption and be steadfast in building community and social cohesion in our societies.

Chile is also committed to the development of regulations for guiding the progress of artificial intelligence in an ethical, transparent and responsible manner, respecting human rights, protecting personal data and promoting the integrity of information and its use in the digital era. No doubt many of us have artificial intelligence applications on our mobile phones, but today artificial intelligence reproduces prejudices and stereotypes resulting from the reinforcement of existing biases in the databases with which they are trained. Are we going to trust the large companies to regulate themselves in this area? History teaches us that that does not work.

The international community must look out for the weakest among us, who are being excluded from this new world in formation, despite the fact that they too are entitled to take part in it. If we do not take action now, for example by demanding algorithm traceability, data audits and corrective human interventions, we might see a new kind of extermination in a few years — the digital extermination of non-hegemonic cultures and, along with it, the loss of humankind's valuable diversity. Let us not allow that to happen.

Artificial intelligence and new technologies can be a significant contribution to the world. Let us recall Asimov's first law of robotics, which, already in the middle of the previous century, urged us to establish that "[a] robot may not injure a human being or, through inaction, allow a human being to come to harm".

And, lastly, I must draw attention to the most important challenge we face as a generation: the climate emergency. Protecting and sustaining life on Earth is a task we must undertake now. I say that because Chile is a country ravaged by increasingly frequent drought, flooding and fires. As Member States know, borders are irrelevant in that regard. We are equally saddened by Cyclone Idai, which devastated Malawi and Mozambique a couple of years ago, or by major fires in Australia, the flooding in Bangladesh, the dry corridor of Central America, the threat the sea poses to the Maldives or the fires happening now in Córdoba, Argentina. Let us not deny science. Let us not deny our responsibility as humankind in the face of those crises.

We are doing our part from Chile — changing our energy matrix and leaving fossil fuels behind, moving towards carbon neutrality, protecting our seas and wildlife areas, taking care of Antarctica — as Chile is a country in Antarctica and

will remain so — and ratifying the Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the conservation and sustainable use of marine biological diversity of areas beyond national jurisdiction, which I invite all countries to sign. I also ask countries to support Chile's nomination of Valparaíso, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, as the headquarters of the secretariat of the treaty I just mentioned.

Given the magnitude of the challenges, isolated efforts are useless. We need everyone, in particular the major Powers and those who benefited from the indiscriminate exploitation of the planet's natural resources for decades, to take responsibility and support those who are currently lagging behind — with resources, not just good intentions. We cannot forget that many of today's developed countries are so because they have plundered with impunity the wealth of other peoples for too long.

There are many challenges, but fate is not written or inevitable. That is why I am hopeful and optimistic about our shared future. It is up to us to build a more just and dignified world for all of the world's inhabitants and for future generations.

Mr. Leucă (Republic of Moldova), Vice-President, took the Chair.

A few weeks ago, Elvira Hernández became the second Chilean poet to win Chile's National Prize for Literature, after Nobel laureate Gabriela Mistral. By way of conclusion, I would like to paraphrase a warning contained in one of her poems: "We are birds of passage, but we have become accustomed to behaving like monuments". Let us not turn multilateralism and the United Nations system into a sterile, static monument. Let us make this great historic achievement, which emerged from the ashes of the Second World War, into robust and renewed energy in 2024 to improve the quality of life of all humankind.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Chile for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Gabriel Boric Font, President of the Republic of Chile, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Edgars Rinkēvičs, President of the Republic of Latvia

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Latvia.

Mr. Edgars Rinkēvičs, President of the Republic of Latvia, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Edgars Rinkēvičs, President of the Republic of Latvia, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Rinkēvičs: First of all, I wish to congratulate His Excellency Mr. Philemon Yang of Cameroon, on assuming the post of President of the General Assembly. I assure him of Latvia's full cooperation along the way.

This year's debate is of utmost importance. It focuses on today's interlinked global challenges. It emphasizes the need for a comprehensive approach that is firmly rooted in the Charter of the United Nations.

Allow me to highlight a few points.

The future of the multilateral system and rules-based order is in all our hands. We shall not allow their selective application or disregard for global norms. The alternative is a terrifying world where force prevails and law perishes.

It is already the third year of Russia's unprovoked full-scale war of aggression against Ukraine. Russia is still testing the global community's resilience and commitment to the rules-based order. This war gravely affects the stability of the region and beyond. It has far-reaching consequences for the principles that uphold sovereignty, territorial integrity and international law. We must ensure that the global order remains resilient in the face of aggression, especially when the aggressor is a nuclear-weapon State and a permanent member of the Security Council.

Russia is trying to tear down what has been built by all of us. Russia is trying to rearrange the international system to benefit only aggressors. Having endured 50 years of Soviet occupation, Latvia deeply understands the value of freedom and independence, as do many other countries represented in the Assembly Hall. Latvia stands by Ukraine.

We continue to call for an immediate and unconditional withdrawal of all Russian troops and military equipment from the entire territory of Ukraine. There can be no compromise regarding Ukraine's sovereignty and territorial integrity. Russia's unprovoked attack has widespread consequences beyond Ukraine's borders. It impacts global food security, nuclear safety and the humanitarian situation.

Access to food is a human right. Hunger must never be used as a political tool. Latvia stands in solidarity with the countries most affected by the food crisis. Latvia has supported grain initiatives and released fertilizer cargoes. We are implementing partnerships for safe and responsible food production in Africa and Central Asia.

Children's rights are human rights. Forcible deportations and illegal adoptions of Ukrainian children by Russia are of serious concern. We call on the United Nations to take a more active stand on that issue. We will contribute to the return of Ukrainian children and their recovery, to the best of our ability.

The right to life, liberty and security is also a human right. Russia continues to deliberately target civilian and critical infrastructure. Its brutal attacks are supported by Belarus, Iran and North Korea. In response, we are determined to help Ukraine in its fight and in rebuilding what has been brutally destroyed.

I call on all Members of the United Nations to support and join the communiqué adopted at the Summit on Peace in Ukraine, held in Switzerland, and to start building a peace process based on the United Nations Charter principles. Russia must bear full legal and financial responsibility for its aggression, and we must spare no effort to ensure comprehensive accountability for all crimes committed by Russia in Ukraine. It will be crucial to support and strengthen the institutions that investigate and prosecute those crimes, as well as to provide justice for the victims and uphold the rule of law. The establishment of a special tribunal that would be able to prosecute the main perpetrators of the crime of aggression would ensure full accountability, and I encourage other countries to support that proposal.

Our attention remains focused on the crisis in the Middle East. Tragically, innocent civilians, including countless children, are bearing the brunt of that crisis. It is imperative for the international community — the United Nations — to support efforts that ensure the protection of all civilians and work towards a durable resolution. Latvia, together with other European Union member States, has called for an immediate ceasefire in Gaza, the unconditional release of all hostages and the provision of humanitarian access at scale. That is crucial to preventing a deepening of the crisis and a regional spillover. We remain hopeful that progress towards ending the hostilities can soon be achieved. We condemn all terrorist attacks on Israel. We recognize Israel's legitimate right to self-defence, but it must be exercised in line with international law, specifically international humanitarian law — the law that has been put in place to protect all civilians. We must also focus on revitalizing the political process, with a view to breaking the cycle of violence

and striving for a just and lasting peace. That peace must address the legitimate aspirations and security concerns of both Israelis and Palestinians. The ongoing escalation reinforces the necessity of pursuing a two-State solution in accordance with international parameters.

The United Nations is a place where no country's voice can be drowned out by Powers with greater resources. The United Nations commitment to the principles of peace and security, justice and human rights empowers us to address challenges that we cannot otherwise tackle alone, and the importance of acting in solidarity for sustainable and inclusive development is clearer than ever. The Summit of the Future has demonstrated our renewed commitment to the Sustainable Development Goals. It accelerates our efforts to eradicate poverty, reduce inequalities and ensure environmental sustainability. The right path towards progress and the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals is through advancing innovation and a science-based and environmentally friendly economy, enhancing the quality of education, strengthening governance and engaging with women, young people and the non-governmental sector on those issues. Latvia has already progressed towards achieving 63 per cent of the set targets and is also helping those most in need. Our development cooperation policy has become more global and more tangible, increasing year by year.

There can be no sustainable development without peace and consistent global action on climate change. The ongoing conflicts and crises around the world are aggravating the effects of climate change. We strongly believe that the Security Council must address climate change as an existential risk to global peace and security. Small island developing States are at the forefront of global environmental crises. In that regard, Latvia welcomes the recent advisory opinion on climate change and international law issued by the International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea. We are also closely following the International Law Commission's deliberations aimed at clarifying the impact of sea level rise on statehood.

Latvia has meaningful experience in building resilience to disinformation and promoting media literacy. We support an online environment that is free and open but also safe and secure. The rising capabilities of artificial intelligence provide a lot of opportunities for growth and development, but the potential for their misuse is a concern.

Latvia also remains increasingly engaged in peacebuilding and prevention in both word and deed. That includes our continuing provision of voluntary financial support to and participation in United Nations peacekeeping missions, as well as our support to the women and peace and security agenda.

The United Nations is not without flaws. Its ability to prevent aggression or resolve conflicts has frequently been questioned. We must acknowledge the shortcomings and address them effectively. Latvia strongly supports the revitalization of the United Nations system and reform of the Security Council. The number of permanent members on the Council must be expanded to make it more effective, inclusive and accountable and to elevate the voice of underrepresented regions. It is high time for Africa to have a permanent presence at the Council table. The continent has been neglected for far too long, and that must change. Furthermore, the small island developing States deserve a non-permanent seat on the Council. Their voices must be heard, especially given the existential threats they are facing. The decision-making process should be revisited as well. No single State should have veto power in the Security Council, especially when it comes to conflicts that permanent members are themselves involved in. That is how to ensure that the Council's permanent members uphold their responsibility to protect peace and security.

The United Nations was once a beacon of hope for the people, but not anymore. We must change that. We must rebuild trust and common values. And we can do that only by working together. Latvia is fully prepared to assume its part of that responsibility. Latvia is running for a non-permanent seat on the Security Council in the 2025 elections for the first time. We stand ready to re-energize that international organ.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Latvia for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Edgars Rinkēvičs, President of the Republic of Latvia, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Santiago Peña Palacios, President of the Republic of Paraguay

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Paraguay.

Mr. Santiago Peña Palacios, President of the Republic of Paraguay, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Santiago Peña Palacios, President of the Republic of Paraguay, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Peña Palacios (spoke in Spanish): We live in a turbulent, volatile world that is going through unprecedented and extremely difficult times with tremendous challenges. Those challenges include armed conflicts, tensions in every corner of the globe, crises in multilateral institutions and the international system, a siege on the values of democracy by the twin threats of populism and authoritarianism, risks of cyberwarfare and the inappropriate application of artificial intelligence, the brutal inequity in the distribution of wealth, and climate change, which is endangering our very existence. Those are just some of the immense problems we are facing. I am afraid that I have not come here today to make a speech that will make us feel good, but rather one that will elicit the discomfort and concern that we should be feeling in the face of what is happening. I think that we must be honest and admit that we are failing — all of us — in building a better world. However, if there is a time and a place to debate and propose the crucial decisions that can change the course of humankind, it is the General Assembly. And thanks to the delicate situation we are living in, it is our duty to do so.

The good news is that not all is lost. As a great military hero and statesman of my country, Bernardino Caballero, said, “The future is the child of the present”. That means that we can have a better destiny if we act here and now. Through that, even with the discouragements that can bring many of us to despair, we can contemplate the bright horizons of the future — but only if we can earn the respect and esteem of future generations, as Caballero crucially added. That is, we simply want to be worthy of the high positions that we occupy today by tackling our problems with clarity, firmness and courage instead of sweeping them under the rug. Despite the difficult reality we live in, I remain optimistic. I do not fear the future, because I trust in the capacity of human beings to overcome challenges. However, it is imperative, indeed obligatory, that we redefine how multilateral institutions function and promote changes to them, such as the elimination of the veto in the Security Council. We need to build frameworks that promote equitable and sustainable development, in which all countries, regardless of their size or power, can benefit equally from global advances. That is the only way that we can fulfil the promises that this forum represents and earn the respect and esteem of future generations.

The maintenance of peace should be the fundamental pillar of multilateralism. Today’s reality paints a sad picture, however. The 20 or so international armed

conflicts and more than 110 active internal conflicts around the world show us that the institutions created to preserve peace have not been able to fulfil their mission. War continues to be a plague that is suffocating humankind. That scourge tears apart the social fabric, annihilating communities and leaving a legacy of immeasurable suffering. Each life lost is a testimony to our collective failure to fulfil the most basic of our responsibilities — maintaining peace and protecting human dignity.

The history of my nation is living testimony to the cruelty and immense suffering that wars bring. During the War of the Triple Alliance, Paraguay endured a conflict of extermination that sadly foreshadowed the genocides of the twentieth century. As another great Paraguayan, Manuel Gondra, once said, Paraguay is a small but proud country, and that is the only reason it survived that bloody war. However, Paraguay knows that the price of war is very high, and that is why we understand better than anyone not only the calamity of war, but also what it means for a small country to be invaded or attacked by more powerful countries. That is why we express our most sincere solidarity with all the victims of armed conflicts, whether internal or international. We reaffirm our firm and determined commitment to the peaceful resolution of disputes, and we advocate the non-use of force as a means of resolving disagreements between nations or peoples, without exception. In that context, we reiterate our firm support for Ukraine and its sovereignty and territorial integrity. We underline the urgency of finding diplomatic solutions that can lead to a fair, comprehensive and lasting peace, with the aim of ending the conflict and ensuring stability in the region.

As we do about Ukraine, we believe that conflicts must be resolved through dialogue and diplomacy, always seeking solutions that respect the fundamental rights of all parties involved. That belief also guides our position in the face of the growing crisis in the Middle East. Our relationship with the State of Israel is founded on solid pillars, such as faith and hope. That is why Paraguay has been one of the countries that has stood most firmly by Israel following the grotesque, targeted terrorist attack by Hamas on 7 October 2023. Today Paraguay reaffirms its recognition of Israel's legitimate right to defend itself. We also reject any biased attempts to attribute equal responsibility to the democratically elected authorities in Israel and the leaders of the terrorist group Hamas. At the same time, we call urgently for the implementation of a solution that can alleviate the humanitarian situation, put an end to the violence, guarantee the immediate release of the hostages and promote a constructive dialogue that leads to lasting peace.

We are deeply concerned about the situation in Africa, where the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees estimates that there are currently around 25 active conflicts, some long-standing and others emerging, all with devastating consequences for the lives and future of the inhabitants of the continent. We hope to see peace and stability restored in that region of the world. We have had enough of violence, war and mere words. As actors on the international stage, we must take firm and effective action.

Today I would also like to take a moment to address the dire humanitarian situation in Haiti, which is a clear example of the shortcomings of multilateralism. Despite numerous international efforts and interventions, the global cooperation efforts have failed to translate into the sustainable peace, governance and security that the Haitian people so need and deserve. Today gangs control much of Port-au-Prince and have plunged the country into a spiral of violence that multilateral mechanisms have been unable to de-escalate effectively. Added to that is a catastrophic humanitarian reality — more than 5 million Haitians are food-insecure and facing a resurgence of diseases such as cholera. Although multiple promises of aid have been made, inadequate financial resources and logistical difficulties have prevented the arrival of timely and sufficient humanitarian assistance. There is a

worrying dissonance between what the international community promises and what actually gets done on the ground. We will stand by the Haitian people in every effort to help that brother country.

My country, like many others present today, has had a past of authoritarianism and dictatorships. That is why today we Paraguayans value the ideals of democracy and the rule of law more than anyone. We can speak with authority. Our country existed for a long time in the shadow of dictatorship, exile and expulsion. However, today our reality is different and vibrant. Paraguay has been reaffirming its democratic vocation through free and transparent elections for more than three decades. Never before have we had so many years of democracy, and I dare to say to the usual doomsayers and pessimists that despite shadows, these years have been my country's happiest.

We Paraguayans may not agree on many things, but we do agree that there is no way to live together other than through democracy and the rule of law. Democracy is simply non-negotiable. That is why I want to condemn loudly and firmly what is happening to our Venezuelan brothers and sisters right now. I reiterate Paraguay's position on the electoral process in the Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela, which ended on 28 July. The process ignored the will of the Venezuelan people and was marked by serious acts by the regime that resulted in persecutions and arbitrary arrests of the main opposition actors. The deterioration of democracy in Venezuela is clear, along with systematic violations of human rights and fundamental freedoms. Added to that are actions contrary to international law, especially with regard to diplomatic relations and the right to asylum. We reiterate our support for the democratic forces in Venezuela that are fighting authoritarianism and for a return to a system that is truly democratic rather than a mere facade.

One of the most important criticisms of global multilateralism is the idea of the equal inclusion of all nations. The concept of "one nation, one vote" often becomes a hollow one if smaller nations are forced to compromise their self-determination in exchange for not being left out of large international markets. Nevertheless, we recognize that regional cooperation remains a vital path to physical and economic integration. The fight to overcome our challenges is impossible without a convergence of the wills of neighbouring countries. In that regard, regional cooperation is the only viable alternative that allows us to work together and design national policies in coordination with other nations.

It is in that spirit of cooperation and strengthening of regional institutions that Paraguay has decided to submit the candidature of its Minister for Foreign Affairs, Rubén Ramírez Lezcano, for the General Secretariat of the Organization of American States (OAS). We are convinced that his leadership will contribute significantly to revitalizing the OAS and promoting a more inclusive and efficient multilateralism that meets the challenges of the present and focuses on the well-being of all the peoples of the hemisphere.

As part of our commitment to a more inclusive multilateralism that leaves no nation behind, today, Paraguay reiterates its unwavering support for those countries that, despite their outstanding global contribution, are still excluded from important international forums like this one. Paraguay not only recognizes, but also deeply values the international collaboration of the Republic of China (Taiwan), a sister nation with which we have forged almost 70 years of solid and meaningful friendship. That friendship is based on the shared values of democracy, the rule of law and free trade. It is a genuine friendship, forged in the adversity of being two geographically small countries in proximity to great Powers. Our fighting spirit, however, is far from small.

At this General Assembly session, we renew our strong support for Taiwan to be an integral part of the United Nations system. We believe that its exclusion is an injustice that we cannot overlook because the values that we share and its contribution to the international community deserve the same recognition as that of any other nation present here. If there is a country that should be part of the United Nations system today and is not yet doing so, that country is Taiwan. Today, we come not only to denounce that injustice, but to raise our voice firmly to alert the international community to the threat to Taiwan's integrity and to the legitimate right of self-determination of peoples. I underscore the importance of peace and stability in the Taiwan Strait. In a world full of tensions, in which conflicts are constantly at risk of spillover, positive and peaceful interaction in that region is vital, not only for Asia's security, but for global stability.

Just as we uphold the principles of peace, justice and international cooperation in all corners of the world, it is equally important to reaffirm our commitment to those values within our own borders. In my country, as I said earlier, we live in a vibrant and full democracy. With a republican system of balance of powers, although our political party has a majority in Congress, we maintain a dialogue with the opposition to carry out the major reforms that the country needs. We are convinced that democracy cannot be empty — it must have content, and, above all, it must achieve results. Here, economic development is crucial to ensure the future strength of democracy. Prosperity is the greatest enemy of crime, of division and of hopelessness. The most effective social policy, I always say, is economic prosperity. However, in order for that prosperity to reach everyone, it is necessary to invest in our human capital and create the conditions for families to get ahead through their own work.

Here, I would like to mention two of the programmes that my Government has been carrying out. The first is the Zero Hunger in Schools programme, a bid to eradicate 100 per cent of hunger in school-age children, born of the conviction that one cannot learn while hungry. The second is the Che Róga Porã programme, which is the first housing access policy in Paraguay aimed at the working class, with quotas for access to housing at the same price as rent, which will enable thousands of Paraguayan families to transform a monthly expense into a family asset. However, there is no development without security. In view of that, at both the national and the international levels, it is logical to adopt an comprehensive vision of security, with a sense of cooperation among the various national and international agencies. That is my vision as President of the Republic.

Finally, we will continue to focus on institutional frameworks and transparency as key conditions for development. Paraguay's recent investment grade rating is a clear reflection of the continuous effort to strengthen our institutions, coupled with a tradition of economic stability that has been consolidated over several decades. Paraguay wants to be, can be and will be a genuine protagonist on the global stage. We are determined to take our place.

Paraguay is a country with abundant natural resources, valuable human capital and a strong focus on creating value chains that promote a green economy, based on the development of sustainable technologies. Our country sets an example in terms of clean and renewable energy production. Hydroelectric power generation is not only a national project, but also a joint initiative with our neighbours, one whose aim is to play a key role in building a more developed, more sustainable and emissions-free world. I firmly believe that Paraguay exemplifies the fact that economic development is entirely compatible with environmental sustainability.

Paraguay shares common challenges with other landlocked developing countries. Those challenges will be addressed in the new programme of action for landlocked developing countries, to be adopted in Botswana this December. Far

from discouraging us, those challenges represent an opportunity for us. We are transforming our difficulties into strengths, taking advantage of our geographical location as a strategic position. Our position in the heart of South America drives us to be the engine of South American integration. With a clear vision, we are committed to becoming the region's logistics hub through the Paraguay-Paraná Waterway and the South American Bi-Oceanic Corridor, which are key axes to revitalize and strengthen the Southern Common Market and Pacific Alliance blocs.

As we consolidate our geographical position as a hub of regional integration and logistics development, it is crucial that that vision of growth be backed by a strong investment in education. Paraguay's success will depend on our ability to prepare future generations for the globalized and competitive world. Along with education, technology is a key tool for development and social inclusion. Our nations face many challenges. However, without a doubt, the question of the ethical application of artificial intelligence and of advances in technology in general stands out here. Moore's Law postulates an exponential growth in the development of new technologies that require us to create new regulatory schemes to protect people, schemes capable of addressing a challenge that is approaching with a speed that is difficult to grasp. Those new techniques, such as sandboxes and co-regulation, must have as their ultimate goal the responsible use of emerging technologies and the equitable application thereof.

In Paraguay, we are deeply committed to preserving our cultural heritage. At the end of this year, we will host the nineteenth session of the Intergovernmental Committee for the Safeguarding of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization, at which we hope that the *Guaranía* will be recognized as an intangible cultural heritage of humanity. In addition, we reiterate our commitment to protecting the fundamental rights of all Paraguay's citizens, the family, and human life beginning at conception, defending the traditional values that have made our nation great.

Despite my critical assessment, I must confess that I am an incurable optimist — I firmly believe that our future is bright and full of opportunity. I therefore believe in those luminous horizons of the future of which I spoke earlier. If we fight for a better present, we will have future days full of light and possibilities.

The defence of democratic values and respect for human rights must continue to be our guide. It is natural for us to have legitimate political differences, but there are principles on which there can be no compromise: democracy, the rule of law and unconditional respect for human rights are fundamental pillars. Although our political or ideological views may differ, that should not divide us or prevent us from moving forward in building cooperation based on solid foundations. If we maintain the ideals of cooperation, mutual respect, integration and fraternity among our peoples as a non-negotiable aim, I am convinced that we will see better days.

In conclusion and despite the tremendous challenges we are facing, I am convinced that, as William Faulkner once said, "man will not merely endure: he will prevail".

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Republic of Paraguay for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Santiago Peña Palacios, President of the Republic of Paraguay, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. To Lam, State President of the Socialist Republic of Viet Nam

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the State President of the Socialist Republic of Viet Nam.

Mr. To Lam, State President of the Socialist Republic of Viet Nam, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. To Lam, State President of the Socialist Republic of Viet Nam, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President To Lam (*spoke in Vietnamese; English interpretation provided by the delegation*): I would like to first congratulate His Excellency Mr. Philemon Yang on his election as the President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. I trust that this session will be a great success. I also commend His Excellency Mr. Dennis Francis, President of the General Assembly at its seventy-eighth session, and His Excellency Mr. António Guterres, the Secretary-General of the United Nations, for their contributions and efforts in coordinating the United Nations endeavours to prevent wars, maintain peace and promote global development cooperation.

The world is undergoing transformative changes of historic significance. Although peace, cooperation and development remain the dominant trends, they are facing new and more serious challenges. Strategic competition among major Powers is becoming more widespread, fiercer and more confrontational. Political disputes, conflicts and the security environment are intensifying. The space for survival and development is narrowing. Risks of conflict, new hot spots, the arms race, tensions, confrontation and direct clashes are increasing. The rise of power politics and egoistic nationalism are challenging international law, eroding multilateral institutions and diminishing faith in global cooperation. The vicious cycle of conflict and violence is escalating in various regions, causing immense suffering to millions of innocent civilians.

The risk of a limited nuclear war, or even a third world war, has not been ruled out.

Non-traditional security challenges, such as climate change, extreme weather events, natural disasters, diseases, resource depletion and an aging population, are becoming increasingly severe, hindering our efforts for development. Poor countries are being left further behind with a widening development gap. Super Typhoon Yagi, which ravaged Viet Nam and other countries in the region, serves as a stark warning of the severe impact that natural disasters and climate change can have on sustainable development for all.

Global food production is sufficient to feed one and a half times the world's population, yet famine is threatening more than 780 million people, and 2.4 billion people are enduring food insecurity. Defence expenditure reached a record \$2.4 trillion in 2023, yet we struggled to pool \$100 billion for climate action. With only a third of the time on the timeline to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) remaining, 80 per cent of the targets may not be met.

Global economic growth is facing difficulties. Decoupling and fragmentation, along with economic pressures and sanctions, are threatening rapid and sustainable development. The fourth industrial revolution offers opportunities for quantum progress, but it also poses security and safety challenges for society and individuals.

Those unprecedented challenges to peace, cooperation, sustainable development and human dignity are affecting this generation and the next. They compel us to unite, act and work together, upholding the role of international institutions, foremost among them the United Nations, and regional organizations, including the Association of Southeast Asian Nations, to achieve the ultimate goal of ending war, abolishing all forms of oppression, exploitation, building peace and creating a better world to bring happiness to all humankind.

In that spirit, I would like to share Viet Nam's vision for a more peaceful, stable, cooperative, prosperous and sustainable future for everyone.

First, as peace and stability are the foundation of a prosperous future, we must promote the observance of international law and the Charter of the United Nations by all States, particularly the major Powers. Each State must act responsibly, fulfil its commitments and abide by international law and the Charter of the United Nations, including fundamental principles such as the peaceful settlement of disputes, the non-use of force, sovereign equality, territorial integrity and respect for the political systems chosen by the people of each nation. States should also contribute to the common work of the international community in line with their capabilities. We must strengthen solidarity, sincerity and trust among nations, uphold dialogue, eliminate confrontation and firmly oppose unilateral embargoes and sanctions that contravene international law and the Charter of the United Nations.

Secondly, we must ensure equitable development for every State, community and individual, recognizing the diverse economic, social and cultural conditions they may have. Every resource must be effectively unleashed, marshalled and utilized for development according to each country's needs. We must prioritize resources where they are most needed for implementing the SDGs, paying particular attention to assisting developing and less-developed countries, especially through preferential loans, the transfer of advanced technologies, investment and trade facilitation, and debt relief for poor countries.

Thirdly, we should urgently create smart global governance frameworks with a long-term vision for science and technology, especially emerging technologies such as artificial intelligence. That will ensure we make progress and enjoy the benefits of those technologies, while actively preventing threats to peace, sustainable development and humankind. In that connection, I welcome the documents adopted at the Summit for the Future, especially the Global Digital Compact (resolution 79/1, annex I). That will serve as a crucial basis for advancing global governance and international cooperation in those areas.

Fourthly, we should adopt innovative thinking to build a transformative future across all sectors, focusing on digital transformation, green transition and global governance transformation. Green transition and digital transformation are essential tools for countries, especially developing ones, to build resilience and self-reliance, enabling a timely and active prevention of and response to shocks, crises and potential disasters. We must also prioritize reforming multilateral mechanisms, especially the United Nations system and international financial and monetary institutions, to ensure better representation, equity and transparency. Enhancing capacity, effectiveness and future-readiness is essential for remaining relevant in our changing world.

Fifthly, we must place the human person at the centre in delivering on our visions. People should be the centre, goal and drivers of all policies and actions at all levels. Investment should focus on the holistic development of the youth, enriching their knowledge and culture, grounded in shared values and a sense of responsibility and contribution.

Viet Nam welcomes the General Assembly's official decision (resolution ES-10/23) to grant additional rights and privileges of participation to the State of Palestine from this session onwards. Viet Nam reaffirms its solidarity with the State and people of Cuba and calls on the United States to lift embargoes and sanctions against Cuba and to remove Cuba from the list of State sponsors of terrorism. We must vigorously promote such actions, since they are practical ways to foster equitable development and happiness for all.

President Ho Chi Minh, a Vietnamese hero of national liberation and an eminent man of culture, once stressed, "Unity, unity, great unity; success, success, grand success". Only through unity and cooperation, with trust and by thinking and acting

as one, can we build a world of peace, sustainable development and human dignity for present and future generations, ensuring no one is left behind.

In today's rapidly changing world, each State plays a vital role in the grand orchestration of our era. Viet Nam is making every effort to move forward towards a future of peace, stability, prosperity and sustainability — not just for our own people but for all nations worldwide. That is Viet Nam's vision, goal and strong commitment to the international community, today and tomorrow.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the State President of the Socialist Republic of Viet Nam for the statement he has just made.

Mr. To Lam, State President of the Socialist Republic of Viet Nam, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. Andrzej Duda, President of the Republic of Poland

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Republic of Poland.

Mr. Andrzej Duda, President of the Republic of Poland, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Andrzej Duda, President of the Republic of Poland, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Duda: I would like to express my sincere congratulations to His Excellency Mr. Philemon Yang on his election to the position of President of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. Poland fully supports his mission and wishes him every success. I also want to extend my thanks to His Excellency Mr. Dennis Francis for his effective presidency during the seventy-eighth session.

I am honoured to be addressing the General Assembly for the tenth time as President of Poland, all the more so because today we are facing huge global challenges that require our solidarity, cooperation and determination. Our presence here reminds us of the mission that the United Nations was established to fulfil after the terrible tragedy of the Second World War — to prevent further conflicts and ensure world peace. This year we mark the eighty-fifth anniversary of the beginning of that massive conflict, which claimed millions of lives. It was Poland that became its first victim. On 1 September 1939, Nazi Germany attacked my homeland and started the Second World War. Two weeks later, on 17 September, the Soviet Union also invaded my country, as an ally of Nazi Germany fulfilling the agreement between Hitler and Stalin — the so-called Molotov-Ribbentrop Pact. Both aggressors deprived us of our independence. Poland found itself in the midst of a brutal occupation by two totalitarianisms, becoming a witness and victim of war crimes that left a mark on our nation and our world's history forever. In my country we know very well what war is, and we know what tragedy and suffering it brings. That is why Poland has always been a strong advocate of measures aimed at preventing conflicts and ensuring peace in the world. Our history and experience incline us to constantly recall the need to respect international law and protect the sovereignty of States.

Today we are once again facing an extremely serious threat to global security. For the past two and a half years we have been watching Russia's brutal aggression against neighbouring Ukraine. It is a flagrant violation of fundamental norms of international law such as the prohibition of the use of force in international relations. The unprovoked aggression is destabilizing the region and posing a direct threat to global order and security. We cannot allow the war to turn into another frozen conflict. That is the most important task for the future. That is why it is so important

today to stop the Russian war in Ukraine, not only to end the suffering of Ukrainians and punish the aggressor but to prevent such heinous actions from becoming a model for others to follow. Ukraine's territorial integrity must be restored within its internationally recognized borders. The logic of conquest and disregard for international law must be stopped, unless we want to agree to live in a world where any country can become a victim of aggression, regardless of its size or location.

Poland is following with equal concern the situation in the Middle East, where the conflict has escalated owing to the brutal Hamas attacks of 7 October 2023. Israel, like every other State, has a right to self-defence. However, those actions must follow international humanitarian law. Poland has consistently supported a two-State solution to the Middle East conflict that would guarantee the right of both Palestinians and Israelis to live in peace and security and with good relations with all their neighbours. As proponents of the principles of equality and the right of nations to self-determination, we believe that the emergence of an independent Palestine would not contradict Israel's interests, while Israel's right to exist cannot be questioned. The two nations are united by space and time, which will remain their common destiny.

We are also deeply concerned about the current situation in Yemen. The ongoing humanitarian crisis is affecting millions of people, and the struggle for control in the country poses a threat to regional security and freedom of navigation in the Red Sea. The international community must do everything possible to ease the suffering of the Yemeni people and restore stability in their country. And we can all see how the ongoing wars, conflicts and terrorist acts in Africa are undermining people's efforts to live and develop in safe and fair conditions. The world must stand with all who are affected by insecurity and help them restore peace through reconciliation and social cohesion.

We cannot achieve peace and security in the world without respect for the law. As President of Poland, I constantly repeat the phrase "peace through law", always emphasizing the fundamental role of international law in maintaining the global order. Our history and experiences have taught us that only adherence to international norms and the protection of the rights of every human being can ensure stability and development. As a country of freedom and solidarity, Poland will always demand respect for human rights, regardless of where they are threatened. Poland has therefore decided to run for a seat on the Human Rights Council for the 2029–2031 term. Our candidacy is an expression of our commitment to the promotion and protection of human rights around the world. We believe that human rights are the foundation of peace and security. Their violation leads to conflicts, while their protection results in stability and development.

We in Poland perfectly understand the perspective of countries that have experienced colonialism. Our history — from losing our statehood in the eighteenth century, to the Second World War, to the fall of communism — has taught us how precious freedom, sovereignty and human dignity are. That is part of our DNA, and we therefore stand with the developing countries in their quest for prosperity, equal treatment and self-reliance. That is why Poland will not stop supporting African societies, as I had the opportunity to personally assure my friends during my visits this year to Rwanda, Kenya and Tanzania, as well as in recent years on my previous visits to the continent, which is so important for Poland, Europe and the whole world in building a shared, safer and more prosperous future. We believe that Africa has the potential to develop its own solutions to its challenges.

However, we recognize that global development in many parts of the world is currently facing serious obstacles. We note with concern that halfway through the deadline for achieving the Sustainable Development Goals set by the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, the progress made in realizing its ambitions

is still insufficient. During this session, Poland will serve as a Vice President of the Economic and Social Council. The motto of our mandate in the Council is “Developing in solidarity”, which is a good summary of our vision of the progress we need. With its forthcoming presidency of the Council of the European Union, which starts on 1 January 2025, Poland will also seek to give new impetus to relations with developing partners. There is a need for better cooperation, real partnership and more solidarity.

Next year we will celebrate the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations. Despite its imperfections, the United Nations remains the foundation of the world order, allowing us to work together for peace, development and human dignity. We believe that the Summit of the Future has given us an opportunity to reflect on the effectiveness of our work and the possibility of improving United Nations structures to make them more responsive to today’s challenges. Poland is ready to discuss reform of the Security Council and other key United Nations bodies, as well as international financial institutions. The world is changing, and our system must change as well if we are to better serve the global community. Our common commitment, enshrined in the Charter of the United Nations, is to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war. Poland will remain faithful to that mission and will support efforts for peace, human rights and sustainable development. I wish all of us fruitful deliberations.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of Poland for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Andrzej Duda, President of the Republic of Poland, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by His Serene Highness Prince Albert II, Sovereign Prince of Monaco

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by His Serene Highness Prince Albert II, Sovereign Prince of Monaco.

His Serene Highness Prince Albert II, Sovereign Prince of Monaco, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Serene Highness Prince Albert II of Monaco and to invite him to address the Assembly.

Prince Albert (*spoke in French*): Almost 80 years ago, the Charter of the United Nations came into being, laying the foundations of our Organization to save succeeding generations from the scourge of war. Its founders believed firmly that no power was more legitimate than that collectively entrusted to this new international Organization. And in the past two days, alongside many of us here, and at the initiative of the Secretary-General, Mr. António Guterres, I have taken part in the Summit of the Future (see A/79/PV.5). Between hope and concern, the Summit enabled us to measure the immensity of the work that is still to be done if we are to ensure a harmonious and peaceful future for our children.

At a time when we are facing a growing number of challenges, we are witnessing an increase in regional conflicts, a resumption of the arms race and nuclear proliferation and a sharp decline in collective security. The extreme violence of conflicts today and the thousands of victims they are claiming around the world is intolerable. Targeted attacks on civilian infrastructure, including schools and hospitals, are flagrant violations of the fundamental principles of international humanitarian law. Similarly, the use of famine as a weapon of war is a heinous crime. Such acts must not go unpunished. Whatever the conflict or the continent where it takes place, international justice must pursue every crime that is committed

and bring the guilty to justice. That is an essential prerequisite for building a just and lasting peace in the long term.

The dividing up of the world that we are witnessing is very disturbing. This should not be a time for war and division but for building coalitions for concrete action and intensifying cooperation, solidarity, mutual aid and dialogue. My country has always believed that multilateralism is the only way forward. The United Nations is at the heart of multilateralism, and it is up to us to implement the road map that we have collectively adopted. As we pledged last year at the Sustainable Development Goals Summit, and again yesterday at the Summit of the Future, we must turn away from the path of destruction and focus on the path to prosperity. The New Agenda for Peace has mapped out a path to help us show greater solidarity and rebuild trust. A number of milestones have already been reached, pointing the way for the near future. Next year's fourth International Conference on Financing for Development calls on us to rethink the international financial architecture to help countries take more sustainable and inclusive paths to development. The World Social Summit, also to be held next year, should provide the impetus needed to achieve greater social justice and contribute to the fight against poverty, Goal 1 of the Sustainable Development Goals.

Sustainable development as a whole cannot achieve the desired effects if it does not include women and girls. In 2025, as we celebrate the twenty-fifth anniversary of Security Council resolution 1325 (2000) on women and peace and security and the thirtieth anniversary of the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action, it is clear that gender equality has still not been achieved, even though it represents equality of rights, responsibilities and opportunities. It is only by guaranteeing women's rights in all the Sustainable Development Goals and the actions of the Pact for the Future that we will achieve greater justice and inclusion. Step by step, at whatever the cost, we must maintain our efforts to promote women's rights and ensure gender equality.

Let us make no mistake. The challenges that pose the greatest threat to humankind in the long term are unquestionably linked to the multidimensional environmental crisis that we are experiencing, for which, I need hardly remind everyone, we are primarily responsible. Climate change, declining biodiversity and ecosystems and the multiple forms of pollution that affect both land and the ocean — the cradle of life — are disrupting the daily lives of millions of people and inflicting considerable economic losses. Faced with this tragedy of the commons, we cannot give in to doubt or despondency. Of course we have to be clear-sighted about the scale of the tasks ahead, but that should not prevent us from being optimistic and having faith in the future. We now have several major international instruments to guide us through the storm — the Paris Climate Agreement, the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework, the Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas Beyond National Jurisdiction (BBNJ) and soon, I hope, a new international agreement to combat plastic pollution worldwide.

The crisis facing us requires a coordinated response. When we take part in the various international forums planned for the coming months, let us therefore bear in mind the need for united and concerted action. The first of these is in Colombia, at the sixteenth meeting of the Conference of the Parties to the Convention on Biological Diversity, where expectations are high and reflect the many challenges we face in implementing the Biodiversity Plan and realizing our 2050 vision of living in harmony with nature. At the end of the year in Baku, at the twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, we will set a new collective climate finance target for developing countries that must meet the immense needs, while remaining realistic and operational.

Creating the conditions to guarantee the right to a future in a healthy environment requires ending upheavals in our ecosystems, with the support of science, but also with the knowledge and expertise of the women and men on the ground who are already suffering the consequences of those changes. I am thinking specifically about small island developing States, which are particularly vulnerable to the effects of sea level rise. The possible disappearance of habitable and productive areas in those States is a genuine threat to their existence.

The Principality of Monaco and its institutions, committed to preserving the oceans, are supporting the project to establish an international group of experts for the International Platform for Ocean Sustainability to be led by UNESCO's Intergovernmental Oceanographic Commission. In that regard, as we move forward in the Decade of Ocean Science for Sustainable Development, 2021–2030, I call on all States to accelerate the ratification process of the BBNJ Agreement, in the hope that it can enter into force in 2025, an important year for the planet with the holding of the third United Nations Ocean Conference in Nice, France. The Conference should make it possible to accelerate our actions and mobilize all actors so as to provide the sustainable solutions that the ocean needs to meet the challenges we are facing. The blue economy also has a role in this area, and the Principality intends to actively play its part by welcoming the Blue Economy and Finance Forum on 7 and 8 June 2025. Lastly, beyond the framework offered by the BBNJ Agreement, I reaffirm my country's commitment to the establishment of solid regulations, based on the best scientific data, that guarantee the effective protection of the marine environment before any mineral exploitation of the deep seabed. These interconnected crises compel us to fundamentally rethink our relationship with nature, which is essential to our survival and welfare.

Amid the challenges and changes facing humankind, the development of artificial intelligence seems inevitable. The emergence and development of this new technology in our daily lives come with opportunities that we must seize, as well as dangers that we must guard against. The Principality of Monaco is committed to capitalizing on the opportunities provided by safe, secure and trustworthy artificial intelligence systems for sustainable development. The rapid technological advances we are witnessing can both accelerate development and provide fertile ground for organized crime and terrorism. It is now up to the international community to establish appropriate standards to ensure that the technology is used ethically, respects everyone's human rights and fundamental freedoms and cannot be misused for military or terrorist purposes.

Apart from that, disinformation represents one of the most insidious threats to our societies today. It is spreading rapidly, fuelled by social media and digital platforms, sowing confusion and eroding trust in institutions and the media. The consequences of manipulating information are serious and can extend to destabilizing our States and exacerbating international tensions. It is therefore essential to strengthen fact-checking mechanisms to protect the truth and preserve the health of our democracies.

We have the necessary tools, whether legal, technological or scientific, to provide sustainable and effective solutions to today's challenges. The Pact for the Future and the eightieth anniversary of the United Nations in 2025 are a historic and unique opportunity for us to advance the intergovernmental process on Security Council reform in order to make our Organization more inclusive and representative of current realities and resolve the crises we face. While the Olympic and Paralympic Games in Paris were a major success, the athletes showed us that effort and perseverance, even in the face of adversity, lead to victory. They have humbly taught us that while victory is the ultimate goal, the path we have travelled and reciprocal competition are equally important achievements. Let us therefore be committed to the process we have defined, together and with determination. Step by step, let us overcome

our obstacles without ever losing sight of our objective — that of preserving peace among nations and ensuring the welfare of the peoples of the United Nations.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Sovereign Prince of Monaco for the statement he has just made.

His Serene Highness Prince Albert II, Sovereign Prince of Monaco, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Mr. David Ranibok Adeang, President and Head of State of the Republic of Nauru

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President and Head of State of the Republic of Nauru.

Mr. David Ranibok Adeang, President and Head of State of the Republic of Nauru, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. David Ranibok Adeang, President and Head of State of the Republic of Nauru, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

President Adeang: As President of the Republic of Nauru, a small island nation with a vision for a more equitable and sustainable future, I bring the Assembly warm greetings from the Government and the people of Nauru.

At this seventy-ninth session of the General Assembly, we gather at a time of unprecedented global challenge and opportunity. As we navigate the complexities of the twenty-first century, Nauru remains committed to the principles of sovereignty, self-determination and international cooperation that have guided our collective progress since the United Nations was founded.

As a nation surrounded by the ocean, Nauru has a vested interest in the responsible stewardship of the ocean's marine resources. We have been at the forefront of international efforts to protect and sustainably use those resources, including developing and adopting the Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity of Areas beyond National Jurisdiction and exploring the wealth of the deep seabed's mineral resources in line with our objectives under the 2050 Strategy for the Blue Pacific Continent.

The greatest risk we face is not the potential environmental impact of mineral recovery but the risk of inaction. There is a risk of failing to seize the opportunity to transform to renewable energy and decarbonize our planet. We cannot let fear and misinformation hold us back. We must rather use the knowledge that we have gathered wisely in order to ensure that deep-sea mineral recovery, under the principle of the common heritage of humankind, does not compromise the integrity of our marine environment. This is not just an economic opportunity but an environmental imperative. We therefore call on the international community not to ignore the science and the progress we have made. Instead, we urge Members and the International Seabed Authority Council to work with us to establish and adopt the robust regulations necessary for the conservation and sustainable use of marine resources. We have the science, the technology and the imperative. Let us rise to the challenge and opportunity before us, employing our advancements for the good of all, and let the time for action be now.

Nauru's story is one not of despair but resilience. Our people have thrived for centuries, living in harmony with the land and the sea. Today, we adapt, innovate and persevere. We are exploring new frontiers because even as we fight the effects of

climate change we must also adapt to the reality that is upon us. Through initiatives like the Higher Ground Initiative project, we are reclaiming land, strengthening our infrastructure and securing our future. Adaptation initiatives to address modern challenges and concerns demand more than technical expertise. They require substantial financial resources, which is an ongoing struggle. When it comes to climate finance, we are too often relegated to the back of the queue.

We must also address the critical issue of access to basic financial services. For nations such as Nauru, equitable access to banking is not merely a convenience, it is a lifeline. Yet we face the growing threats of de-risking and the loss of correspondent banking relationships. That challenge transcends financial concerns and strikes at the heart of our sovereignty and dignity. Our nation's struggles cannot be measured by income alone. We are vulnerable in myriad ways, and the global financial system must evolve to reflect that complex reality. We are encouraged by the Assembly's recent adoption of the Multidimensional Vulnerability Index (resolution 78/322), and we further call on the World Bank, the International Monetary Fund, international financial institutions and multilateral development banks to integrate the Index into their frameworks. It is not just another statistic. It is a tool that provides a more accurate picture of our national circumstances, including our strengths, challenges and potential.

One of the most pressing issues of our time is the rising tensions between global Powers. Nauru has long believed in the importance of maintaining good relations with all nations, great and small. We are friends to all and enemies to none, guided by our motto of "God's will first". Our restored diplomatic relations with the People's Republic of China are a testament to the fact that even the largest and smallest of countries can find common ground and work for their mutual benefit. Nauru is proud of its strong and growing relationship with China, and I want to take this opportunity to commend China's recent agreement with Japan on the ocean discharge of Fukushima nuclear-contaminated water. That historic accord represents a significant step towards addressing a pressing issue of global concern.

As a staunch friend of Cuba, we continue to call for an immediate and unconditional end to the decades-long embargo imposed on it. As we know, conflicts and tensions persist across many regions of the world. In our shared pursuit of progress and prosperity, it is crucial to acknowledge that conflict impedes growth and undermines community stability. We must therefore intensify our efforts to foster peace and development free from the shadow of conflict. Let us reaffirm our commitment to building bridges of understanding, nurturing empathy and promoting reconciliation. We must understand that peace and development are not separate entities but intertwined pillars of human progress. Peace creates an environment in which individuals can thrive, communities flourish and nations prosper. In the absence of conflict, societies can better allocate resources to education, healthcare, infrastructure and sustainable economic growth, fostering the advancement of all. Let us work together for a future in which everyone can live in dignity, harmony and opportunity, leaving behind a legacy of peace for generations. By prioritizing conflict resolution, we pave the way for resilience, progress and shared prosperity. We must focus on building bridges — not walls — and work for a more integrated, connected world. Inclusivity and engagement are vital as we strive for full economic and financial participation, ensuring that no country — large or small, and regardless of its development status — is left behind. That is a call for collective action that we must all heed for the sake of our shared future.

Reform of the Security Council, which is long overdue, must reflect the geopolitical realities of the twenty-first century. It is evident that the current structure of the Council has been a subject of debate, with legitimate concerns about representation, effectiveness and the ability to address current security issues. The imperative for

peaceful resolutions and pursuing lasting peace in conflict-affected regions further underscores the critical need for a reformed and strengthened Council. Let us be the leaders who bring about a new era of peace and reconciliation.

In our fight against climate change, we continue to call on the Secretary-General to appoint a special representative on climate and security. We are pleased to endorse the call for a fossil-fuel non-proliferation treaty, and we urge countries to back that initiative for a sustainable and equitable future. We also eagerly await an advisory opinion of the International Court of Justice on States' obligations regarding climate change and will closely follow and support the implementation of the Court's guidance in the pursuit of climate justice. Nauru is pleased to welcome the adoption of the ambitious Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1), but we are disappointed about the removal of action 21, addressing the issue of security threats posed by the climate crisis. Alongside members of the Group of Friends on Climate and Security, my delegation advocated for the inclusion of that action with a view to addressing those threats, but its removal was a non-negotiable issue, despite our flexibility and willingness to compromise. We believe it is vital to stress the gravity of that decision. Now, before I conclude, I would like to make the following calls to action.

Let me say to the developed nations that they should recognize their historical responsibility for emissions and honour their obligations under the Paris Climate Agreement. They should provide the climate financing and technology transfer they have promised. And they should support our efforts to transition to renewable energy, enhance our climate resilience and protect our biodiversity.

Let me say to those who seek to block our efforts to find renewable energy resources that they should not dismiss the potential of deep-sea minerals outright. They should not ignore the science and the progress we have made. They should rather work with us to establish the robust regulations necessary for responsible mining. In line with the theme of this year's session of the General Assembly, we must accelerate our efforts without delay because the climate crisis will not wait for us to get our act together.

Let me say to our fellow developing nations that we extend our hand to them in solidarity. Let us share knowledge, resources and solutions. Let us amplify our collective voice, for in unity there is strength.

Let me say to the United Nations that we call on it to fulfil its founding promise. It should be a bastion of multilateralism, a resolute champion of the vulnerable and a bold catalyst for the transformative change that our world so desperately needs.

I would like to conclude by reminding everyone that leaving no one behind is not a mere platitude but a moral imperative. It is a call to action and a reminder that our fates are intertwined and that the advancement of all hinges on the advancement of the least among us. That is the vision enshrined in the Charter of the United Nations and the promise of the Sustainable Development Goals. Nauru may be small in size, but its resolve is immense. We will continue to fight for our homeland and our future generations. Let us act together with urgency and ambition, and in the belief that a better world is possible. May God bless the Republic of Nauru and the United Nations.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President and Head of State of the Republic of Nauru for the statement he has just made.

Mr. David Ranibok Adeang, President and Head of State of the Republic of Nauru, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Agenda item 8 (continued)**General debate****Address by Mr. Kashim Shettima, Vice-President of the Federal Republic of Nigeria**

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Vice-President of the Federal Republic of Nigeria.

Mr. Kashim Shettima, Vice-President of the Federal Republic of Nigeria, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: I have great pleasure in welcoming His Excellency Mr. Kashim Shettima, Vice-President of the Federal Republic of Nigeria, and inviting him to address the Assembly.

Mr. Shettima (Nigeria): As the President assumes the leadership of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session, our world is confronted by profound moral questions whose resolution will require more than the habitual remarks from this elevated rostrum. They are questions about the ultimate purpose of our Organization — the United Nations itself — and how it can remain relevant and resilient. It is with those sentiments that I want to convey to the President the warm and fraternal greetings of my countrymen and women and their congratulations on his assumption of the presidency of the Assembly. Let me assure him of my delegation's full cooperation in the discharge of his onerous responsibilities during his tenure. In the same vein, I would like to express my appreciation to his predecessor, His Excellency Mr. Dennis Francis, for the many remarkable achievements recorded during his stewardship.

It gives me particular pleasure to commend His Excellency Secretary-General António Guterres for his commitment to the cause of peace and development and the democratization of the United Nations to reflect the need to correct the historical injustice that has been done to Africa. I am also delighted to note the steadfast support given to the Secretary-General by our own sister and compatriot, Deputy-Secretary-General Amina Mohammed, as she shares the burden of leadership and responsibility in leading a complex organization like the United Nations.

The theme of this year's General Assembly leaves us in no doubt that there is still work to be done to bridge the gap between the aspirations and the realities confronting our world today. It also underscores the need to remind ourselves that the United Nations stands for inclusiveness, anchored on the tripod of peace, sustainable development and human rights. Today the pillars of the Organization are threatened. They risk being broken by the relentless pursuit of individual national priorities, rather than the collective needs of the nations that are assembled here today. While commitment to multilateralism offers us the surest guarantee of global action to address the existential challenges we face, singularity and nationalism are undermining the aspirations towards the peaceful and collective resolution of such challenges. From last year's summit, and indeed from previous years, we have carried over the numerous challenges of terrorism, armed conflict, inequality, poverty, racial discrimination, human rights abuses, food crises, hunger, irregular migration, piracy, global pandemics, hyperinflation, nuclear proliferation, the grinding debt burden, climate change and a host of other vexations. The continued manifestation of those challenges attests to our failings rather than to any lofty achievements on our part. Billions of dollars are being committed to the prosecution of wars and the fanning of the embers of conflict.

Yet we always recoil from bringing out the resources we need to build peace and deliver life's necessities to people. The question of governance is at the heart of our problems and also the solution to them. We recognized that in Nigeria when, on

12 June, we celebrated a quarter of a century of unbroken democratic rule. We are no less proud of that achievement than the fact that, during the past two decades, a sustained process of democratization has swept over Africa. However, the return of unconstitutional changes of Government and forceful military takeovers in some countries of the Sahel underscore the fragility of democracy when it is not backed by economic development and sustained peace and security. It is such fragility, rather than the milestones that democratic governance has achieved in Africa, that should matter most in our deliberations at this and other high-level segments of the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session. While we abhor all forceful changes of Government, we can also recognize the impatience in cities and villages over the sometimes-slow and grinding turn of the wheel of democracy. Our people need employment. They need decent livelihoods. They desire good and affordable education and healthcare for their children and families. They need to live in healthy, safe and secure environments. They need hope, and they need opportunity. They desire to live in peace and tranquillity to pursue whatever gives them happiness and contentment. When Governments fail to deliver, the people are bound to question the utility of democracy and other ideals like the rule of law.

The global debt burden undermines the capacity of countries and Governments to meet the needs of their citizens. Creeping trade barriers and protectionist policies are destroying the hopes for prosperity of peoples and nations. Unbridled competition rather than cooperation is discouraging incentives and driving away investments. Above all, insecurity is driving people into unprecedented hardship and misery that, in turn, affect the people's confidence in democracy. It is the duty of the international community to bring back confidence in democratic rule and constitutional order by paying more attention to the needs and aspirations of the people, rather than paying lip service to human rights, sustainable development and peace. We need the substance of democracy, not just the form. We cannot build durable societies with the threat of terrorism, banditry and insurgency growing in our countries and regions. Indeed, violent extremism remains an existential threat to both national and international peace and security and development. We are making concerted efforts to contain and roll back that threat. The high-level African counter-terrorism meeting hosted by Nigeria in April 2024 and its outcome, the Abuja declaration, promise to provide solutions to the challenges presented by terrorists and insurgents.

Climate change is a driver of insecurity, which also poses a veritable challenge to sustainable development. A few weeks ago, large areas of my country were inundated by seasonal flood waters, including one of our largest cities, Maiduguri, in the north-east. Other parts of Nigeria also experienced similar tragedies, occasioning the loss of lives and property. We need not remind ourselves to remain faithful to the implementation of the commitments that we all made voluntarily at the various meetings of the Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change. Failure to do so is merely to postpone the inevitable. No country is immune from the effects of climate change. It is better that we cooperate and collaborate to meet this ever-increasing challenge, rather than remain in our shells, waiting for the inevitable to happen. A common challenge requires a common solution. Nigeria stands ready to meet its obligations in terms of mitigation and adaptation measures nationally and regionally, with the active participation of other countries and international partners.

Conflict resolution is the main reason that the United Nations exists. But the task of prevention becomes all the more difficult when conflict becomes normalized, when even the condemnation of violence and civilian casualties and calls for a ceasefire are somehow regarded as controversial. As we emphasized at the Abuja high-level ministerial meeting, we must renew our focus on conflict prevention. Indeed, addressing the root causes of conflicts is often the first step towards providing long-term solutions. Clearly, some of the root causes of conflicts are social

in nature, including poverty, hunger, ignorance, inequality and exclusion, as well as other forms of injustice. In the Sudan, other parts of our continent and further afield, foreign actors are exacerbating those tensions to prolong conflict and deepen the suffering of innocent people.

Today we are all witnesses to the heart-wrenching situation in Gaza and other Palestinian territories. We cannot discuss war and peace, conflicts and their resolution, or humanitarian imperatives today without reflecting on the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, which has been raging since 7 October 2023. Of course, the conflict predates that period and has been simmering for the better part of half a century. What that tells us is that the international community has failed to live up to the spirit and aspirations of the United Nations to rid the world of inequality and violence and the domination of one people by another. Justice is antithetical to revenge. Freedom is an inalienable right and a natural entitlement that cannot be denied to any people. The Palestinian people deserve their independence. They deserve to have a home of their own on territories already recognized by the Assembly itself and international law, which is being routinely ignored. Nigeria continues to urge efforts to bring back on track the two-State solution, which offers the prospect for a new beginning for the region.

Nigeria reaffirms its commitment to supporting United Nations peacekeeping operations. We recognize the need for Africa to build strong and professional armies to meet the multiple challenges we face. Consequently, we reiterate the call for international support to operationalize the African Standby Force, in addition to the provision of requisite support and resources to ensure the upgrade, take-off and effectiveness of a centre of excellence on issues of counter-terrorism in Africa.

The reform of the Security Council is critical if the United Nations is to strengthen its relevance and credibility in our rapidly changing world. Some permanent members of Security Council have offered encouraging, if tentative, indications of support on the issue of the reform of the Council. We welcome the change in tone and urge an acceleration in momentum to the process. The Security Council should be expanded in the permanent and non-permanent member categories to reflect the diversity and plurality of the world. We fully support the efforts of Secretary-General Guterres in that regard. Africa must be accorded the respect that it deserves in the Security Council. Our continent deserves a place in the permanent members category of the Security Council, with the same rights and responsibilities as other permanent members.

The assumption of Mr. Yang's stewardship of the General Assembly presupposes that he will be seized of the progress of the implementation of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). We note that most developing countries are lagging significantly behind in the achievement of the Goals, largely owing to a lack of resources available to finance their implementation and the burden of unsustainable external debt. It is our expectation that the adoption of the Pact for the Future will change the narrative, reposition economies and be translated into concrete measures that provide solutions to the challenges faced by developing and least developed countries. That is particularly significant in our region and in the Sahel, where human development indices are low and depressing.

It is for that reason that we reiterate the call by countries — especially those of the global South — for reform of the international financial architecture and the promotion of a rules-based, non-discriminatory, open, fair, inclusive, equitable and transparent multilateral trading system. We are aware of the debilitating impacts of corruption on global prosperity and national progress. The proceeds of corruption and illicit financial flows constitute a huge chunk of resources needed for sustainable development. The recovery and return of such funds to their States of origin is a fundamental principle of the United Nations Convention against Corruption.

Therefore, the international community must promote practical measures to strengthen international cooperation to recover and return stolen assets and to eradicate safe havens that facilitate illicit flows of funds from developing countries to developed economies.

There is also an urgent need to promote fair and inclusive tax regimes in the world. Nigeria helped to introduce the resolution entitled “Promotion of inclusive and effective international tax cooperation at the United Nations” (resolution 78/230). We acknowledge the progress made in the adoption of the terms of reference of a United Nations framework convention on international tax cooperation. We should deepen that initiative and work towards such a convention. Similarly, we must ensure that any reform of the international financial system includes comprehensive debt relief measures to enable sustainable financing for development. Countries of the global South cannot make meaningful economic progress without special concessions and a review of their current debt burden.

My Administration pays due regard to the imperative of creating a national environment conducive to investment and ease in doing business. Last year, President Bola Ahmed Tinubu signed four executive orders to curb double taxation. The Government also established a presidential task force for a review of fiscal policy and tax reform. Those measures are geared towards not only boosting investor confidence in Nigeria but also ensuring that investors make reasonable profit from their investments.

While the world is transitioning into the fourth industrial revolution, Africa remains energy deficient. The push for the accelerated implementation of SDG 7 for affordable and clean energy must therefore take into account Africa’s precarious situation. Nigeria believes that natural gas remains central to the search for solutions to the energy challenges that Africa and the international community face. Access to affordable, reliable and cleaner sources of energy is more than an environmental or development issue — it is a key factor in social peace and international security.

Nigeria remains unwavering in its commitment to SDG 13 on climate action, including the net zero ambition and the transition from fossil fuel energy to clean energy. As a demonstration of that commitment, the Government established a presidential committee on climate action and green economy solutions and appointed a special presidential envoy on climate action. We will redouble our efforts to address the challenges posed by climate change, including the urgent need to transition away from fossil fuel energy.

Yet such commitments must be juxtaposed with the principle of common but differentiated responsibilities and the relevant provisions of the Paris Agreement on climate change of 2015. The Paris Agreement provided for developed countries to take the lead in the quest to achieve net zero and to offer support, including financing, to developing countries for the actualization of the climate change Goal. Worthy of note is the Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage for vulnerable countries, secured at the twenty-seventh Conference of the Parties (COP) to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change in Egypt and expanded at COP 28 in the United Arab Emirates. It is our expectation that, during this year’s seventy-ninth session of the General Assembly and at the upcoming COP 29, to be held in Azerbaijan in November, we will go a step further by providing developing countries — especially African countries — with access to the loss and damage fund, including the \$100 billion pledged by developed countries to mitigate the negative impacts of climate change.

In this age of digital innovation, we must address the emerging divide between the global South and the global North. With the evolution of artificial intelligence, that divide risks becoming wider still. The United Nations should work towards

eliminating barriers to the digital economy in Africa, such as the high costs of Internet services and intellectual property rights. Furthermore, there is a need to work towards common global standards to regulate cryptocurrency trading platforms. That is the most effective way to provide confidence in those new markets and limit the potential for instability. Our own experience in Nigeria, as in other countries, shows that new technologies, when not properly regulated, can facilitate organized crime, violent extremism and human trafficking. In our own case, the trading of cryptocurrency helped to fuel speculation and undermined macroeconomic reforms.

Separately, we have also witnessed — in rich and poor countries alike — the corrosive impact of unfiltered hate speech and fake news across social media. There is much more that we could and should do, together, to strengthen those guard rails that will help release the most progressive elements of the new technologies shaping our world and curb those more destructive tendencies.

We are particularly mindful of the imperatives of achieving the advancement of youth and women as a factor in national development and peace and security. Nigeria has developed its own national action plan on women and peace and security, as well as a national action plan on youth and peace and security, to ensure the participation of both women and youth in the peace and security sector. The Summit of the Future cannot be deemed successful without setting clear, ambitious and achievable development goals to address the various challenges facing our youth. In line with that aspiration, the Nigerian Government will continue to invest in Nigerian youth through initiatives like the revitalization of the national youth investment fund for 2024, focused on youth empowerment and entrepreneurship.

As much as the global family still grapples with the crippling consequences of the coronavirus disease pandemic, the greatest lesson that we have learned is never again to treat any health situation with levity. In line with SDG 3, we must continue to work together to ensure the good health and well-being of all. There is no disease that should be relegated to the background owing to some perceived classification of its seriousness or importance.

Migration is a complex and polarizing issue that affects rich and poor countries alike. Nigeria is a country of origin, transit and destination. We are a major stakeholder in the global migration dynamic and understand the challenges and benefits it brings. Accordingly, I wish to reiterate our support for the Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration. The Global Compact, which we should all continue to support, represents our collective efforts to provide major safeguards for the treatment of migrants.

I will conclude by reaffirming Nigeria's steadfast commitment to the deepening of multilateralism, just as we did 65 years ago from this rostrum, when we joined the United Nations as the 99th Member State. We remain committed to that desire "to remain on friendly terms with all nations and to participate actively in the work of the United Nations Organization" (*A/PV.893, p. 535*), as expressed by our founding Prime Minister, Sir Abubakar Tafawa Balewa.

It is my hope that our deliberations this year will result in solutions that will address our collective challenges and accelerate the attainment of the Sustainable Development Goals and the advancement of peace and human dignity for the sake of present and future generations.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Vice-President of the Federal Republic of Nigeria for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Kashim Shettima, Vice-President of the Federal Republic of Nigeria, was escorted from the rostrum.

Address by His Royal Highness Prince Salman bin Hamad Al Khalifa, Crown Prince and Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Bahrain

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Crown Prince and Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Bahrain.

His Royal Highness Prince Salman bin Hamad Al Khalifa, Crown Prince and Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Bahrain, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Royal Highness Prince Salman bin Hamad Al Khalifa, Crown Prince and Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Bahrain, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

Crown Prince Al Khalifa: It is my honour to be here today and to convey to you, Mr. President, the greetings and best wishes of His Majesty King Hamad bin Isa Al Khalifa. I would like to begin by offering my congratulations to you, Mr. President, on your election as President of the seventy-ninth session of the General Assembly. I wish you every success in guiding this important work. I also extend my deep appreciation to His Excellency the Secretary-General for his tireless efforts in advancing the noble objectives of this Organization across the globe.

Eight decades ago, at the dawn of the nuclear age, humankind found itself engulfed in a devastating war, fraught with peril and uncertainty. The world was in desperate need of order and of a system of accountability and governance. The United Nations was created to become a pillar of stability — a vital institution the world relied on to prevent unspeakable atrocities from ever happening again. Whether through the formation and application of international law, the promotion of diplomatic consensus, the investment in development programmes or the deployment of peacekeeping missions, the United Nations and its specialized agencies have together stood firm to reflect the spirit of global civic responsibility.

The number of world leaders participating in this year's General Assembly is a testament to that enduring spirit. Nineteen years ago, I had the honour of standing here and addressing this historic Hall (see A/60/PV.7), in a statement in which I touched on the pressing challenges confronting our world at the time — poverty, famine, deadly infectious diseases, civil wars and weapons of mass destruction. Those global challenges not only persist but have intensified. We find ourselves in a far more dangerous and unpredictable time, owing to major tectonic shifts in the global geopolitical order. In addition, revolutionary new technologies have emerged that will fundamentally reshape the world as we know it. Environmental and health challenges that know no borders have also multiplied and grown in complexity, requiring us all to work together regardless of our differences.

The very systems designed to uphold the international order are under strain. Eighty years after its formation, as the threats and challenges we collectively face evolve, this important institution, which our global community relies on to safeguard the international rules-based order, must evolve as well. Today, we support the calls for reform of the United Nations to ensure that it reflects current geopolitical realities so that it is equipped to continue carrying out its important global mandate for decades to come. That reform should be holistic, consensus-driven and encompass all the decision-making bodies of the United Nations, including the Security Council.

The peace dividend that followed the end of the cold war is now a distant memory. Today, we stand on the precipice of a new era, with new challenges, and we must recommit to peace as the bedrock on which we build collective prosperity and enduring hope for all. For as we all know, it is far easier to destroy than it is to build.

Today, we see Governments disregarding the established rules-based order as they pursue policies rooted exclusively in self-interest. We see a preference for

brinksmanship and the use of force — of questionable legality — to resolve disputes. We see the rise of radicalism, extremism and rogue non-State actors sowing chaos and discord. In Gaza, we see Palestinians living through an unprecedented humanitarian disaster, with more than 40,000 people killed, many of them women and children. The protection of innocent life is enshrined in international law and is a moral and religious responsibility. It is clear that what is required is the implementation of an immediate ceasefire, the release of all hostages and the adoption of an irrevocable path to the creation of a viable, independent Palestinian State, and it must happen now. That will achieve a comprehensive and lasting peace, deliver security and prosperity to all nations in our region and prevent the spread of a wider regional conflict.

In the West, we witness widespread suffering as the intractable conflict in Ukraine persists. In the East, we see tensions continuing to rise in the South China Sea, raising grave concerns of a wider military escalation and further erosion of the integrity of the international rules-based order. The tolls of those conflicts are borne by humankind — by families, by communities and by our future generations. Those conflicts undermine growth, stifle opportunity and endanger the hopes that we hold for our children.

The Kingdom of Bahrain has long been a vocal advocate of pluralism and multiculturalism — that is who we are. In August, and in line with His Majesty King Hamad bin Isa Al Khalifa's vision that mutual respect for our shared humanity is essential for sustaining global harmony, Bahrain launched the King Hamad Award for Peaceful Coexistence. His Majesty the King has also called on the international community to convene an international peace conference on the Middle East. As the current holder of the presidency of the League of Arab States, the Kingdom of Bahrain urges all nations to join us in that vital initiative, which seeks to strengthen efforts to achieve a just, comprehensive and lasting peace in the region. Diplomacy and dialogue must prevail. Indiscriminate violence, conflict and fragmentation will only drive us farther from this noble goal.

In the Kingdom of Bahrain, we have committed ourselves to ensuring that our citizens are at the core of all our national development programmes. We have worked tirelessly to ensure that they are equipped with the skills necessary to deliver prosperity and growth to themselves and to their community. As we look to the future, we will spare no effort to provide our citizens with opportunities to connect with the wider world in order to compete, innovate and succeed. We prioritize the issues that unite us all: housing, healthcare, education and delivering jobs and prosperity. We focused our government ministries and agencies on a set of priorities, reached out to the private sector and civil society and wove together a spirit of one team focused on delivering those programmes.

Today's world is, in many ways, more fragile than the one that emerged from the Second World War. That is because the global challenges today go beyond geopolitical conflict. We are seeing the devastating impacts of unsustainable development on the world's environment, and as a result of conflicts and fragmentation, we have seen global hunger return and increase. We have also witnessed first-hand the alarming effects of illnesses such as the coronavirus disease, which showed how quickly the global order can be disrupted. Those crises must not be treated in isolation. They are interconnected and represent a systemic threat to humankind. It is imperative that like-minded countries come together, with the objective of revitalizing, adapting and renewing our institutions to effectively address today's significant challenges and deliver on the ambitious commitments set by the Sustainable Development Goals and the recently adopted Pact for the Future (General Assembly resolution 79/1). That can be achieved only through system-wide reform that encompasses pivotal multilateral organizations such as the World Bank, the International Monetary Fund and the World Health Organization, as well as the United Nations. The international

rules-based order is not sustained by hopes or dreams. It is the product of robust international institutions and security constructs that are fit for purpose.

As a Member State of the United Nations and a member of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation, the League of Arab States and the Gulf Cooperation Council, the Kingdom of Bahrain has always been committed to the path of multilateralism. We believe firmly that working alongside our allies and in accordance with the rules of international law is the surest way of guaranteeing our long-term prosperity. That is also why Bahrain and the United States concluded a historic agreement in 2023 to forge a new model for security and shared prosperity. The Comprehensive Security Integration and Prosperity Agreement is designed not as a bilateral arrangement but as the beginning of a multilateral framework that aims to bring together countries with an equal interest in delivering stability and prosperity. It is a model for how nations can promote an inclusive vision grounded in mutual respect and shared goals.

Mr. Tōnē (Tonga), Vice-President, took the Chair.

Such partnerships can go beyond the geopolitical dimension and enter the world of emerging technologies as well. Through meaningful international collaboration, we can harness the transformative potential of technologies such as artificial intelligence to advance shared goals of global development, peace and prosperity. However, that will require a united global front, and today we call for an international treaty governing the development of artificial intelligence to ensure that such technologies contribute to peace rather than exacerbating existing conflicts and become forces for creation and innovation, not destruction and division. Bahrain believes that engaging in wide-ranging partnerships such as these will be crucial to advancing the cause of multilateralism and ensuring that cooperation becomes the cornerstone of our collective security frameworks. Through such agreements, we are confident that the Middle East and the global community can build a future rooted in peace, economic growth and a rules-based international order that benefits all people.

The challenges we face today are not insurmountable if we act with a collective will and determination to define a revitalized international architecture built on shared values and a renewed commitment to multilateralism that prioritizes the welfare of all nations. Some issues are just too important for us not to rise above our differences. Let us together reaffirm our shared responsibility to uphold and protect human dignity and ensure that the international order remains a force for good. We owe that to future generations, to the values we cherish and to the world we seek to protect. Learning to live together is indeed the noblest of endeavours.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Crown Prince and Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Bahrain for the statement he has just made.

His Royal Highness Prince Salman bin Hamad Al Khalifa, Crown Prince and Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Bahrain, was escorted from the General Assembly Hall.

Address by Ms. Giorgia Meloni, President of the Council of Ministers of the Republic of Italy

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the President of the Council of Ministers of the Republic of Italy.

Ms. Giorgia Meloni, President of the Council of Ministers of the Republic of Italy, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations Her Excellency Ms. Giorgia Meloni, President

of the Council of Ministers of the Republic of Italy, and to invite her to address the Assembly.

Ms. Meloni (Italy) (*spoke in Italian; English interpretation provided by the delegation*): We are living in very complex times, and the shared nature of the challenges of our era is forcing us to think about things in a completely new way. The wound inflicted on the rules-based international order by Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine is having destabilizing effects far beyond the borders within which it is unfolding, with a domino effect that is reigniting other flashpoints and even causing them to erupt. Democratic political systems are facing unprecedented threats. Geoeconomic fragmentation is growing, and all of us must deal with its consequences, especially the most vulnerable nations. The path to reducing environmental emissions has reached a crossroads, caught between ideological approaches and a solidarity that is in short supply, especially among the major greenhouse-gas emitters. Water and energy scarcity is having an increasingly serious impact on development, food security and the social stability of entire communities. The exploitation of religious faith has become a source of tension, or worse, of persecution — millions worldwide are suffering for professing their faith, with Christians at the top of the list of victims.

We are witnessing the groundbreaking advent of generative artificial intelligence — a revolution that raises entirely new questions, although I am not sure we should call it “intelligence”. Intelligence entails asking questions, not answering them through data-processing. In any case, unlike any other innovation in history, this technology is a blueprint for a world in which progress no longer optimizes human skills but supersedes them, with potentially tragic consequences, especially for the labour market, with wealth becoming even more concentrated at the top. It is no coincidence that Italy made this issue a top priority of its presidency of the Group of Seven (G7), because we want to do our part in defining a global governance for artificial intelligence that is able to strike a balance among innovation, rights, labour, intellectual property, freedom of expression and democracy.

That complexity, compounded by deeply intertwined challenges, tells us one thing above all. The problems of the so-called global South are also the problems of the global North, and vice versa. Homogeneous blocs no longer exist, and the interdependence of our destinies is a fact. By comparison to the way we thought in the past, we are therefore being called on to think outside the box. The challenge is to effect a decisive paradigm shift in relations between nations and in terms of how multilateral bodies work. The goal is to build an entirely new model of cooperation. I am personally convinced that this new model can and must be based on a number of principles that unfortunately are not a given — mutual respect, concrete action and collaboration. If we are to do that, we must relate to each of us on an equal footing and rekindle our capacity to listen to others in order to understand their thinking — the basis for any form of mutual trust.

It is precisely because we believe in that approach that Italy convened all of the events under its presidency of the G7 this year in an open format, with a very broad outreach involving every continent, the Group of 20, the African Union, the economic and financial institutions and the multilateral development banks. We have shown that the G7 is not a sealed fortress seeking to fend off others but rather a group that offers values and is open to the world.

The turning point in Italy's relations with Africa in particular also comes to mind. We have made the Mattei Plan, our investment plan for Africa, operational at the bilateral level, with pilot projects in nine of the continent's nations, creating strategic partnerships with each of them. We have structured operational synergies with the European Union's Global Gateway and the G7's Partnership for Global Infrastructure and Investment. We have built new financial instruments with the African Development Bank and the World Bank, with a view to enabling the flow

of both public and private resources. We have devised innovative solutions such as the G7 Apulia Food Systems Initiative to strengthen food production and food security, as well as Africa's capacity to support the production and distribution of clean energy. We have decided to support strategic projects for Africa such as the Lobito Corridor.

We have done all of that without ceasing to involve and exchange inputs with our African interlocutors, because we intend not to impose but rather to share and choose priority sectors of intervention together, as well as areas of action where we can contribute added value. We have offered our perspective and our cooperation with concrete projects that are already giving results. We are turning 36,000 hectares of desert terrain in Algeria into fertile land for crop cultivation and building a local facility for processing and production. In Kenya, a biofuel plant is in development, to be completed by the end of 2025 and able to support as many as 200,000 farming enterprises. We have collaborated on a large environmental recovery plan in western Ethiopia.

I would like to once again reiterate our objective with respect to the tens of thousands of people who are considering desperate journeys in order to enter Europe illegally. First of all, we want to guarantee their right to not have to emigrate and cut ties with their homeland simply because they have no choice. That is a desperate decision that reckless and increasingly powerful criminal organizations profit from. A year ago, from this rostrum, I proposed that we declare a global war on human traffickers (see A/78/PV.7), and I am pleased that the appeal did not fall on deaf ears. The G7 has reached a coordination agreement aimed at dismantling criminal networks.

However, we need to do more, and the United Nations needs to do more, because these criminal activities are taking on different forms. One such is slavery, understood as trafficking in human beings, which the General Assembly has played a fundamental role in definitively eliminating from the world. We will not return to the past. Defeating the slave trade of the third millennium is possible, and we can do it if we join forces with greater cooperation and joint initiatives among our police forces, intelligence services and judicial authorities, as well as by adopting the "follow the money" formula. That was something that the great Italian judges Giovanni Falcone and Paulo Borsellino understood and that became a model even at the international level in the fight against criminal organizations. It is a method that Italy also intends to use to strengthen its cooperation with Latin America, because there is a common denominator linking organizations that profit from human trafficking in Africa to those that manage narco-trafficking in Latin America, or the abominable and unscrupulous abduction of children to make them rich men's sex slaves, depriving them of both a present and a future.

Unfortunately, as in too many other regions of the world, Latin America's legitimate aspirations for freedom and democracy, the aspirations of tens of millions of people, continue to be unfulfilled. I am thinking in particular of the Venezuelan people, to whom we are giving our full solidarity and support. The international community cannot just stand by and watch as the results of the elections on 28 July have still not been recognized two months later, while at the same time there has been brutal repression, the death of dozens of protesters, the arbitrary arrest of thousands of political opponents and the incrimination and exile of the opposition presidential candidate. It is our duty to raise our voices.

In 2025 we will be celebrating the eightieth anniversary of the Charter of the United Nations, which enshrines the principles and values that are currently being put in question by none other than a permanent member of the Security Council. We in Italy will not cease defending those principles and values, because they serve as a guarantee for all, especially those countries that are less equipped to defend

themselves. Not only is no one above the law, but on the contrary, the law is all the more necessary to defend the more vulnerable. We therefore cannot turn our backs on Ukraine, which is defending its borders, sovereignty and freedom.

We also affirm the right of the State of Israel to defend itself from external attacks like the one that occurred on 7 October 2023. At the same time, we ask Israel to respect international law by protecting the civilian populations who are also victims of Hamas and its destructive choices. Based on the same reasoning, we clearly believe in the right of the Palestinian people to their own State. However, for that to happen, we need Palestinians to follow a leadership that is inspired by dialogue, stabilizing the Middle East and autonomy. The Abraham Accords demonstrated the possibility of advantageous coexistence and cooperation on the basis of mutual recognition. If that is the basis on which we all have to work, it is now imperative to reach a ceasefire in Gaza without further delay and to secure the immediate release of the Israeli hostages. We cannot continue to witness tragedies like those we have seen in southern and eastern Lebanon involving helpless civilians, many of them children.

That said, next year's anniversary is a historic opportunity to understand, finally, whether we like it or not, that today's problems involve and are the business of all of us. We must be able to question ourselves with humility and awareness. That also requires serious reflection on multilateralism and the capacity of international organizations in this era to rise to the challenges that we are facing. Obviously, I am also talking about the United Nations and its capacity for reform, starting with what is useful and necessary — not what is easier. Italy firmly believes that no reform of the architecture and functioning of the United Nations, starting with the Security Council, can happen without considering the principles of equality, democracy and representativeness. It would be a mistake to create new hierarchies with new permanent seats. We are open to discussing reform without prejudice, but we want reforms that represent everyone better and not just a few.

This is a difficult time to be called to govern our countries. Everything around us is changing and being put in question. The very few certainties we thought we had are no longer the same. Destiny is challenging us and putting us to the test. But we can show that we are up to the task. We can show our citizens, our children and ourselves — perhaps above all ourselves — that we can govern. As a great Italian patriot, Carlo Pisacane, a protagonist of the Risorgimento that united Italy into a nation, said, every reward can be found in the depths of my conscience. We have to face problems instead of pushing them away. We must look at what is important and useful. That is our duty. It is a hard one but it is necessary, and as always, Italy is ready to do its part.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the President of the Council of Ministers of the Republic of Italy for the statement she has just made.

Ms. Giorgia Meloni, President of the Council of Ministers of the Republic of Italy, was escorted from the rostrum.

Address by Mr. Aziz Akhannouch, Head of Government of the Kingdom of Morocco

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Head of Government of the Kingdom of Morocco.

Mr. Aziz Akhannouch, Head of Government of the Kingdom of Morocco, was escorted to the rostrum.

The Acting President: I have great pleasure in welcoming His Excellency Mr. Aziz Akhannouch, Head of Government of the Kingdom of Morocco, and inviting him to address the Assembly.

Mr. Akhannouch (Morocco) (*spoke in Arabic*): I am pleased to congratulate Mr. Philemon Yang on his election to preside over the General Assembly at its seventy-ninth session and to wish him every success in fulfilling his mandate. I want to thank his predecessor, Mr. Dennis Francis, for his work in making the Assembly's previous session a success. I also want to take this opportunity to reaffirm the Kingdom of Morocco's full support for the efforts of Secretary-General António Guterres to enable our Organization to rise to our global challenges, especially his initiative to hold the Summit of the Future (see A/79/PV.3).

Every year, we gather here to find ourselves faced with rapid, complex developments in the international context, which we discuss and exchange views on. In the face of our societies' changing needs and the challenges confronting our countries, the rapidly occurring changes at the level of social media, information technology and artificial intelligence are significant and interconnected. The issue of collective security that was the *raison d'être* of the United Nations has given way to uncertainty focused on other areas of human activity. We now face the challenges of redefining our own production and consumption methods, our governance models, even the very structures of our societies. His Majesty King Mohammed VI affirmed that in a message to the participants in the annual meetings of the World Bank Group and the International Monetary Fund, held in Marrakech, when he said,

“At a time when our planet is facing climate change, which has imposed a new reality that the data is confirming every day, the world is still mired in problems that until recently we thought were resolved, in large part through the rules and multilateral organizations created in the wake of the Second World War.”

We should therefore ask ourselves if multilateralism has reached its limit. Is it now time to come up with alternatives to global governance? Must we choose between multilateral action and the many ideals that bring us together?

Morocco has based its multilateral diplomatic doctrine on the high directives of King Mohammed, premised on ambition, clarity, innovation and realism. It is designed to ensure cooperation with our traditional partners. It also enables us to build necessary frameworks with new partners, based on the principles of effective solidarity and the sharing of experience and benefits, with the fundamental imperative of meeting our security, development and stability challenges at the same time.

For the Kingdom of Morocco, multilateral action has not been and never will be based on outdated idealism or short-term opportunism. Despite all its failures and shortcomings, multilateral action is still the only way to address our collective challenges and major threats. But it is no longer enough merely to reflect on the failures of multilateral action and declare our intention to reform it. We need to give that reform new impetus by mobilizing all segments of society, especially women and young people. In the wake of the Summit of the Future, we cannot move forward towards our future without bringing all those sectors on board with a view to crystallizing the shape and content of future comprehensive multilateral action. Similarly, we consider multilateral action a tool for developing countries to defend their interests and focus on their national priorities in order to benefit from cooperation opportunities and share experience and expertise.

One of the major challenges facing our planet is climate change, and the facts tell us that it is African countries that are most affected by its impacts while themselves making only a minor contribution to that climate change. On top of that, African countries have to allocate large portions of their revenues to pay down debts. We therefore believe that the relevant lending frameworks and rules should be changed

to take account of the constraints that African States labour under when it comes to adapting to climate change. The Kingdom of Morocco therefore calls for creating innovative financing mechanisms that can enhance the positive impact of climate funds so as to resolve such debt crises. And we should accelerate the work of reforming the international financial architecture in order to meet the needs of developing countries by facilitating access to equitable loans that guarantee investment in their development. We also call for better representation of African countries on the governing boards of the World Bank and other multilateral banks in order to make them more democratic. We need to take a productive approach in this area, since debt crises are having a major negative impact on the economies of African countries. That is why Morocco, which has led the Like-Minded Countries Supporters of Middle-Income Countries for the past two years in New York, continues to call for multilateral actions capable of maintaining the development momentum that those countries have been able to achieve.

Guided by King Mohammed's insightful vision, the Kingdom of Morocco continues to call for realistic, collective and pragmatic multilateralism to meet the needs of the African continent through effective decision-making mechanisms. That is the approach adopted and implemented by the Kingdom of Morocco in areas such as climate change adaptation, migration and the fight against terrorism. We are also working to implement social justice by organizing structured workshops for streamlining coverage, which we have funded in the amount of 29 billion Moroccan dirhams, an initiative that benefits millions of people through direct social assistance.

In affirming Morocco's Atlantic-facing policy, based on our steadfast belief that the Atlantic coast will become a space for human communication, economic integration and a truly continental and international hub, King Mohammed has sought to strengthen the ties of integration and cooperation among African countries that share the Atlantic coast through the Rabat Process for African Atlantic States. That initiative is in keeping with the policy of cooperation among countries of the South and is aimed at demonstrating solidarity so as to make the Atlantic African space an area of peace, stability and development. The King has also launched an ambitious initiative aimed at enhancing coastal countries' access to the Atlantic, based on his belief that the region has every right to participate in the global economy. That pioneering royal initiative is designed to be a pillar of prosperity, peace and stability for that part of the continent. And it is in the same spirit of solidarity that we are planning the construction of a future Morocco-Nigeria gas pipeline, a project for regional integration and economic revitalization aimed at promoting development along the Atlantic coast with the participation of 13 African countries. While our continent can depend on the wisdom of its leaders and the creativity of its young people, it needs increased solidarity and cooperation from the international community to face its challenges.

The Kingdom of Morocco remains committed to the peaceful settlement of disputes in accordance with the Charter of the United Nations. We are therefore committed to reaching a definitive political solution to the regional dispute over the Moroccan Sahara — based exclusively on Morocco's initiative for autonomy and within the framework of our territorial integrity and national sovereignty — that will open up new opportunities for development in the region. The consistent and growing support of many countries for Morocco's sovereignty over its Sahara and for the Moroccan initiative for autonomy sends a clear message to other parties and to the United Nations that it is time to advance a political solution on that basis through the round tables that have been organized and in accordance with the relevant Security Council resolutions. In that context, Morocco supports the efforts of the Secretary-General and his Personal Envoy for Western Sahara to relaunch the political round tables with the participation of the four parties concerned, in order to achieve a

realistic, practical, lasting and consensus-based political solution, in accordance with Security Council resolution 2703 (2023).

In that regard, we reiterate Morocco's position, which King Mohammed has reaffirmed to the Secretary-General, that there can be no political process on this issue outside the framework of the round tables set by the United Nations, with the full participation of Algeria, and no solution outside the framework of the Moroccan autonomy initiative. Nor can there be any serious political process unless the armed militias return to a ceasefire, as the members of the Security Council have called for. At the same time, the Moroccan Sahara is currently experiencing one of our country's highest rates of development, thanks to projects being carried out under our new development model for the southern provinces. Through their democratically elected representatives on the regional councils, the people of the region are fully involved in every stage of the implementation of that ambitious political decision-making framework, and their active participation in Moroccan political, economic and social life demonstrates their firm attachment to Morocco's territorial integrity and the Moroccan character of the Western Sahara.

In his speech on the occasion of the twenty-fifth anniversary of his accession to the throne, King Mohammed reiterated that our focus on our country's internal situation has not made us forget the tragedy that our brother Palestinian people are enduring. In that context, my country joins other Islamic and Arab States in expressing our deep concern about the dangerous and unprecedented situation that has prevailed in the occupied Palestinian territory since October 2023, in which thousands of civilians, mostly children and women, have been killed and injured, in addition to the massive destruction of Gaza and the total blockade imposed on it, in flagrant violation of international laws and humanitarian values. King Mohammed has outlined his vision for replacing the logic of crisis management with the logic of working to find a definitive solution to the conflict that includes the following elements.

First, while ending the war in Gaza is an urgent priority, it must go hand in hand with the opening of a political horizon that will lead to the establishment of a just and lasting peace in the region. Secondly, ensuring the conduct of negotiations to revive the peace process between the Palestinian and Israeli parties requires combating extremism on any side. Thirdly, security and stability in the region can be established only within the framework of a two-State solution whereby Gaza is an integral part of the territory of an independent Palestinian State with East Jerusalem as its capital.

On the humanitarian front, in his capacity as Chair of the Al-Quds Committee of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation, King Mohammed has worked to ensure the opening of an unimpeded land route for the delivery of urgent food and medical assistance to the people of Gaza.

The Kingdom of Morocco also expresses its deep concern about the recent developments in the Middle East. All the indications suggest that we are facing a truly unprecedented situation that could lead to a spillover of the conflict, which could plunge the entire region into an unpredictable phase with unpredictable repercussions. King Mohammed has repeatedly stressed that the lack of a political horizon in the context of the Palestinian question is one of the most important factors fuelling the conflict in the Middle East, and he has warned against continuing to manage the Israeli-Palestinian conflict without a realistic and sustainable solution. Continuing in this way has led to frustration, disappointment and a succession of devastating catastrophes with humanitarian consequences, and it has had dangerous repercussions for stability and peace in the Middle East and international peace and security. I would like to express Morocco's full solidarity with the people and the Government of Lebanon regarding the aggression to which Lebanon has been

subjected, and to demand that its territorial integrity and national sovereignty be respected.

The enormous number of global challenges that we are facing makes it essential that we mobilize our collective conscience, improve our working methods and strengthen our fundamental values. The United Nations today faces the task of restoring the spirit of active solidarity, collective responsibility and genuine humanitarianism on which it was built, and of addressing decisively the question of reform as we approach the celebration of the eightieth anniversary of our Organization. The Summit of the Future held at the beginning of this session (see A/79/PV.3), the upcoming Second World Summit for Social Development 2025 and the Sustainable Development Goals of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development are all visions of a shared future and road maps that must be implemented so that we can work collectively to prevent any further delays in the development agenda.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Head of Government of the Kingdom of Morocco for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Aziz Akhannouch, Head of Government of the Kingdom of Morocco, was escorted from the rostrum.

Address by Mr. Alexander de Croo, Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Belgium

The Acting President: The Assembly will now hear an address by the Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Belgium.

Mr. Alexander de Croo, Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Belgium, was escorted into the General Assembly Hall.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I have the honour to welcome to the United Nations His Excellency Mr. Alexander de Croo, Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Belgium, and to invite him to address the Assembly.

Mr. De Croo (Belgium): As leaders from around the world flock to the United Nations this week, they should have only one ambition — to find a way out of the conflicts in the Sudan, the Middle East, Ukraine and all too many other places. The conflicts are close to our homes and cities, bringing war, famine and terrible tragedies to families and societies. When we take a brief look back in time, history teaches us a lesson. After Andrei Sakharov developed the first Soviet hydrogen bomb in 1955, he was seriously troubled by the nuclear arms race and Soviet doctrine. He saw that human rights and human dignity were an absolute necessity — a precondition — not just for nuclear security but for the prevention of war. The fight for human rights defined him and turned him into an international advocate, culminating 20 years later in his being awarded the Nobel Peace Prize. In its remarks, the Nobel Committee noted that Sakharov fought against the abuse of power and every form of violation of human dignity. Looking at the world today, it is crucial to remember Sakharov's legacy. Across the globe, human dignity and the rule of law are receding, and in many cases they are absent. And where respect for human life and the promise of the rule of law fades, armed conflicts loom large. History may not repeat itself, but it surely rhymes.

In the Middle East, decades of dehumanizing the enemy have led to a vicious cycle of violence, resulting in the killing of more than 40,000 people in less than a year. That human-made conflict has proved to be one of the deadliest in decades. While it did not start with the horrific terrorist attack that killed more than 1,400 Israeli citizens almost a year ago, on 7 October 2023 Belgium immediately acknowledged Israel's right to defend itself and called for the unconditional release of all hostages. Early on in the Gaza war, my Government warned against the lack of respect on both sides for international humanitarian law, and against the disproportionate attacks,

with blatant disregard for Palestinian civilians' lives. Almost a year later, we must sadly acknowledge that the extremes on both sides still set the tone of the conflict. Fanatics believe that military power can end it. That is a delusion. To achieve peace, we need a proper road map and political courage, not mere tactics to remain in power another day. We have been calling for an immediate and lasting ceasefire for many months, but today it seems more distant than ever. The hostilities have to stop before the whole region becomes engulfed in violence. Actions speak louder than words.

Belgium has imposed an arms embargo. We have never ceased our support to the United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East and other humanitarian organizations. Together with the European Union we have imposed sanctions on Hamas, as well as on extremist settlers and settler organizations. With every innocent life lost in Gaza and every discovery of a dead hostage, the prospects of future peace may seem more distant than ever. Today Gaza lies in rubble. More than 15,000 people need prosthetics because they have lost limbs, and 10,000 of them are children. Where is the human dignity in all of this? However, there is a way out. I am convinced that it starts with recognition of both Israel and Palestine's right to exist, based on the 1967 borders. We should all engage with Palestinian and Israeli leaders who recognize those rights and oppose both antisemitism and anti-Palestinian feelings. Only then can we start to articulate a viable pathway for a two-State solution.

Vladimir Putin has been waging war in Europe for more than two years. And there is one simple truth. He can stop the illegal and unprovoked invasion of Ukraine right now. His madness continues to have devastating consequences for the Ukrainian people. One man alone can stop the killing of thousands of civilians and can end the continuing violence against the Ukrainians, whose future has been put on hold. Only he can end the shelling, the bombing and the indiscriminate attacks on bridges, roads, energy infrastructure, hospitals, schools and people's houses. The widespread and disturbing brutality has been documented by various independent international inquiries, and none of us can, or should, look away.

Over the past year the Belgian Ukraine fund has spent €1.7 billion on military equipment and humanitarian aid and on rebuilding Ukraine's hardest-hit regions. Belgium's development agency is helping Ukraine's recovery and its preparations for joining the European Union. The people of Ukraine will soon be battling another cold winter. That is why we are winterizing the provision of energy in hundreds of hospitals. Over the past two years we have often said the words, "For as long as it takes". We do not take that promise lightly. As the Russians continue to bomb cities, Ukraine's call for more air defence is pure self-protection. How else can they keep their citizens safe? The build-up of a strong Ukraine F-16 force is an integral part of our support. We will transfer all our fighter jets as they leave the Belgian Air Force. The total will amount to at least 30 over the coming years. We want to help protect the people of Ukraine. The aggressor shall not win, and that is why our support for Ukraine stands strong. To all who aspire to peace, it will come about only when we force President Putin to stop his aggression against Ukraine.

(spoke in French)

Clearly we live in a polarized and deeply divided world. That might lead us to believe that multilateralism has failed at every level, which would be a mistake. A year ago, the Agreement under the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea on the Conservation and Sustainable Use of Marine Biological Diversity Beyond National Jurisdiction was adopted (resolution 78/272). That collective initiative is proof that it is still possible for us to unite in the face of a climate and environmental emergency. Another example of progress has been the global response to mpox and that of the Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention to the epidemic. The

European Union and Belgium have invested significantly in vaccine production and access in Africa. And we need more solidarity and cooperation.

Those words may sound idealistic and naive, but we can overcome our common challenges only by working together. Extreme weather events are proliferating around the world, and, just last week, heavy rains caused flooding in large parts of Eastern and Central Europe. Our planet and all its life forms are facing enormous challenges. However, this is no time to despair and lower our expectations. On the contrary, human ingenuity, sustainable competition and meaningful changes in behaviour can mitigate the effects of climate change and help us adapt. We have redoubled our efforts to increase our ambitions vis-à-vis the climate and the oceans. We are ready to work with our partners, particularly in the most vulnerable African countries, by providing funding and building their capacity. This autumn, the sixteenth Conference of the Parties to the Convention on Biological Diversity, to be held in Cali, and the twenty-ninth Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, to be held in Baku, will once again be key moments for the future of people of the planet.

(spoke in English)

In all these years, the talk of conflict prevention, peacebuilding and peacekeeping has multiplied. Unfortunately, that has not stopped conflicts from becoming more numerous, deadly and enduring. The number of aid workers killed has reached record highs. The number of refugees continues to rise year after year. Our common humanity seems to be in a deep crisis, which brings me back to the lessons that Andrei Sakharov taught us. Where human rights and human dignity are absent, conflicts loom large and the most vulnerable bear the brunt. A new beginning, which the Pact for the Future (resolution 79/1) calls for, must therefore start with our recommitment to the Charter of the United Nations, the rule of law and respect for human dignity.

The Acting President: On behalf of the General Assembly, I wish to thank the Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Belgium for the statement he has just made.

Mr. Alexander de Croo, Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Belgium, was escorted from the rostrum.

The meeting rose at 8 p.m.